

The Noble Saṅghāṭī Sūtra, a Synonym of the Dharma

Ārya Saṅghāṭī Sūtra Dharma Paryāya · Toh 102 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་ཟུ་གེ་མིང་འོ་ཆོས་ཀྱི་རྒྱ་གདམས།

The Noble Saṅghāṭī Sūtra, known in Sanskrit as the Ārya Saṅghāṭī Sūtra Dharma Paryāya and in Tibetan as Phakpa Zung gi Do chö kyi Namgrang, is a Mahāyāna sūtra belonging to the general sūtra literature of the Buddhist canon. It takes the form of a discourse delivered by the Buddha at Vulture Peak Mountain in Rājagṛha before a vast assembly of monks and bodhisattvas, and it is renowned for its emphasis on the extraordinary merit generated simply by hearing, reciting, or venerating the text itself. The sūtra is Toh 102 in the Kangyur, where it is classed among the general sūtras, and it has been particularly influential in Tibetan Buddhist practice as a text whose very recitation is held to purify negative karma and plant the seeds of future awakening.

In the language of India: Ārya Saṅghāṭī Sūtra Dharma Paryāya. In the language of Tibet: The Noble Saṅghāṭī Sūtra, a Synonym of the Dharma. First Section.

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time, the Blessed One was dwelling in Rājagṛha, on Vulture Peak Mountain, together with a great Saṅgha of thirty-two thousand monks, namely: the Venerable Kauṇḍinya Who Knows All, the Venerable Mahāmaudgalyāyana, the Venerable Śāriputra, the Venerable Mahākāśyapa, the Venerable Rāhula, the Venerable Bakula, the Venerable Surakṣita, the Venerable Subhadra, the Venerable Candanaśrī, the Venerable Viṣaghna, the Venerable Subhūti, the Venerable Nāvika, the Venerable Nandika, and others of this kind — thirty-two thousand monks in all.

Also present were sixty-two thousand bodhisattvas, great bodhisattvas, namely: the bodhisattva, great bodhisattva Maitreya; the bodhisattva, great bodhisattva Sarvadatta; the bodhisattva, great bodhisattva Kumāraśrī; the bodhisattva, great bodhisattva Kumārasthita; the bodhisattva, great bodhisattva Kumārabhadra; the bodhisattva, great bodhisattva Akṣaya; the bodhisattva, great bodhisattva Mañjuśrī; the bodhisattva, great bodhisattva Samantabhadra; the bodhisattva, great bodhisattva Priyadarśana; the bodhisattva, great bodhisattva Bhaiṣajyasena; the bodhisattva, great bodhisattva Vajrasena; and others of this kind — sixty-two thousand

bodhisattvas, great bodhisattvas in all.

Also present were twelve thousand sons of the gods, namely: the son of the gods Bhavasimha, the son of the gods Bhadra, the son of the gods Subhadra, the son of the gods Dharmaruci, the son of the gods Candanagarbha, the son of the gods Candanasthāna, the son of the gods Candana, and others of this kind — twelve thousand sons of the gods in all.

Also present were eight thousand daughters of the gods, namely: the daughter of the gods Dundubhī, the daughter of the gods Śobhāvatī, the daughter of the gods Maheśvarā, the daughter of the gods Netraśrī, the daughter of the gods Prajāpatipratīṣṭhitā, the daughter of the gods Balādhārā, the daughter of the gods Dhanaśrī, the daughter of the gods Subāhu, and others of this kind — eight thousand daughters of the gods in all.

Also present were eight thousand nāga kings, namely: the nāga king Anavalamba, the nāga king Elapatrī, the nāga king Atyuccagāmin, the nāga king Kumbhagarbha, the nāga king Kumbhaśīrṣa, the nāga king Sukṛta, the nāga king Suprīta, the nāga king Supatra, the nāga king Hastimukha, and others of this kind — eight thousand nāga kings in all.

All of them, turning toward Rājagṛha, turning toward Vulture Peak Mountain, and turning toward the Blessed One, came to that place. They arrived, bowed their heads to the feet of the Blessed One, circumambulated the Blessed One three times, and took their places in the presence of the Blessed One. The Blessed One, without saying anything, gave his consent.

Then the bodhisattva, great bodhisattva Sarvadatta rose from his seat, arranged his outer robe over one shoulder, placed his right knee on the ground, bowed with palms joined in the direction of the Blessed One, and addressed the Blessed One with these words:

Blessed One, tens of millions of gods, tens of millions of daughters of the gods, tens of millions of bodhisattvas have assembled, Blessed One, along with tens of millions of śrāvakas and the kings of the nāgas, and they are gathered here to hear the Dharma. By what manner of entering into the way of Dharma does a Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and fully awakened buddha cause elderly sentient beings, upon merely hearing it, to have all their karmic obscurations purified, and cause young sentient beings to strive with earnest application in wholesome qualities and attain what is supreme — so that they do not decline from those wholesome qualities, do not utterly decline, and will not fall away

from them? Please teach well the manner of entering into such a way of Dharma.

When this was said, the Blessed One addressed the bodhisattva, great bodhisattva Sarvadatta with these words:

Sarvadatta, it is excellent, excellent that you wish to ask the Tathāgata about this matter. Therefore, Sarvadatta, listen well, take it to mind, and I shall explain it to you.

"So be it, Blessed One," replied the bodhisattva, great bodhisattva Sarvadatta, and he listened in the presence of the Blessed One. The Blessed One then spoke to him thus:

Sarvadatta, there is a category of Dharma (paryāya) called Zuñ that is still in circulation in Jambudvīpa. If any person hears this Dharma category called Zuñ, that person's five crimes of immediate retribution will be purified, and they will become irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening.

Sarvadatta, what do you think? Would one say that those who hear this Zuñ sūtra generate a mass of merit equal to the merit accumulated by a single Tathāgata? No, Sarvadatta, it should not be regarded in that way.

Sarvadatta asked: Then how should it be regarded?

The Blessed One declared: Sarvadatta, those bodhisattvas, great bodhisattvas who hear this Zuñ sūtra will each generate a mass of merit equal to the mass of merit of as many Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas as there are grains of sand in the river Gaṅgā.

Sarvadatta, all those who hear this Dharma category will become irreversible. All of them will come to behold the Tathāgata. All of them will become inseparable from beholding the Tathāgata. All of them will fully and perfectly awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. As for all the wholesome qualities they will attain, the wicked Māra will not be able to impede them. Sarvadatta, all those who hear this Zuñ sūtra will come to know arising and cessation.

Then all those bodhisattvas rose at that moment from their seats, arranged their outer robes over one shoulder, placed their right knees on the ground, and addressed the Blessed One:

Blessed One, how great is the mass of merit of a single Tathāgata?

The Blessed One declared: Sons of good family, hear the measure of the mass of merit of a single buddha. Consider, for example, all the drops of water in the great ocean, all the finest particles of dust in Jambudvīpa, and all the grains of sand in the river Gaṅgā — the mass of merit of a single buddha exceeds even the combined mass of merit of all the bodhisattvas abiding on the ten grounds who are equal in number to all of those combined.

Those sentient beings who hear this enumeration of Dharma categories will generate a mass of merit even greater than that — and the extent of that mass of merit cannot be fathomed by any process of counting. Sarvavikrāntagāmin, at that time and on that occasion, whoever hears these words and is filled with great delight will generate an immeasurable mass of merit.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Sarvavikrāntagāmin, addressed the Blessed One with these words: Blessed One, which sentient beings are those who are utterly parched for the Dharma?

When this was asked, the Blessed One declared to the bodhisattva, the great being Sarvavikrāntagāmin: Sarvavikrāntagāmin, these two kinds of sentient beings are utterly parched for the Dharma. Which two? Sarvavikrāntagāmin, the first is a sentient being who holds an equal mind toward all sentient beings. The second is one who, having heard the Dharma, teaches it equally and correctly to all sentient beings.

The bodhisattva Sarvavikrāntagāmin asked: Blessed One, who is it that, having heard the Dharma, teaches it equally and correctly to all sentient beings?

The Blessed One declared: Sarvavikrāntagāmin, the first is one who, having heard the Dharma, dedicates it to awakening — and whenever one so dedicates it to awakening, one is thereby utterly parched for the Dharma on behalf of all sentient beings. The second is one who enters the Great Vehicle — such a one is always and constantly utterly parched for the Dharma.

Then tens of millions of gods, nāgas, humans, and goddesses rose from their seats and, pressing their palms together before the Blessed One, addressed him with these words: Blessed One, we too are utterly parched for the Dharma. Blessed One, please bring to complete fulfillment the aspirations of ourselves and of all sentient beings.

At that moment the Blessed One smiled. Then the bodhisattva, the great being Sarvavikrāntagāmin, rose from his seat and, turning to face the direction of the Blessed One, pressed his palms together and bowed, and addressed the Blessed One with these words: Blessed One, what is the cause and what is the condition for this smile?

The Blessed One then declared to the bodhisattva, the great being Sarvavikrāntagāmin: Sarvavikrāntagāmin, all those sentient beings who have gathered here and will fully awaken to unsurpassed and perfectly complete awakening — they will all come to accomplish the full range of a Tathāgata's conduct.

The bodhisattva Sarvavikrāntagāmin asked: Blessed One, by what cause and by what condition will the sentient beings who have gathered here fully awaken to unsurpassed and perfectly complete awakening?

The Blessed One declared: Sarvavikrāntagāmin, it is excellent, truly excellent, that you think to ask the Tathāgata about this matter. Sarvavikrāntagāmin, therefore listen well to this distinctive teaching on dedication.

Sarvavikrāntagāmin, long ago in the past, across incalculable eons, there appeared in the world a Tathāgata, an arhat, a perfectly and completely awakened buddha called Ratnaśrī — endowed with knowledge and conduct, a Sugata, knower of the world, an unsurpassed guide and tamer of persons, teacher of gods and humans, a blessed buddha. Sarvavikrāntagāmin, at that time and on that occasion I was a young brahmin boy. All those sentient beings whom I had arranged and set within the wisdom of a buddha — at that time and on that occasion they had become deer in the wilderness,

At that time and on that occasion I made this aspiration: "May all those deer who are now utterly tormented by suffering be reborn in my buddha-field. May I, by my own hand, establish them individually in the wisdom of a buddha." The deer too, upon hearing those words, declared, "So may it be!" Through that root of virtue, Sarvavikrāntagāmin, those sentient beings have now arrived here, and they shall awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete enlightenment.

Then the great bodhisattva Sarvavikrāntagāmin, having heard this great source of joy from the Blessed One, addressed him with these words: "Blessed One, for how long a lifespan will those sentient beings endure?"

The Blessed One declared: "The lifespan of those sentient beings will endure for eighty eons."

The bodhisattva Sarvavikrāntagāmin asked: "Blessed One, how long is an eon?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, listen. Suppose a certain person were to build a wall twelve leagues in breadth and three leagues in height, fill it entirely to the brim with sesame seeds, and then, after every thousand years had passed, take out a single sesame seed from that wall full of sesame. Even if that person were to exhaust all those sesame seeds in that manner, so that the wall was left without foundation or base, still the eon would not be exhausted. Sarvavikrāntagāmin, consider another example as well: suppose there were a mountain in a great wilderness fifty leagues across and twelve leagues in height, and a certain person were to build a dwelling on the face of that mountain, and every hundred years were to wipe it once with a cloth of Kāśī silk — if by doing so the mountain were eventually worn away to nothing, still the eon would not be exhausted. Sarvavikrāntagāmin, such is the measure of an eon."

Then the great bodhisattva Sarvavikrāntagāmin rose from his seat and addressed the Blessed One thus: "Blessed One, if even a single dedication can produce such a vast accumulation of merit that those beings will dwell happily for a lifespan of eighty eons, what need is there to speak of serving the teaching of the Tathāgata with the greatest frequency and devotion?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, listen. If merely hearing this Dhāraṇī teaching results in a lifespan of fourteen hundred thousand eons, what then need be said of Sarvavikrāntagāmin copying the Dhāraṇī Sūtra in writing and reading it? Sarvavikrāntagāmin will generate an exceedingly vast accumulation of merit. Whoever bows down to the Dhāraṇī Sūtra from the depths of their heart with a pure and faithful mind will remember their past lives for ninety-nine eons, will become a wheel-turning king for sixty eons, and in this very life will be beloved by all. Sarvavikrāntagāmin, such a one will not die by the sword, will not die by poison, and will not be harmed by spells. At the moment of death too, ninety-nine million buddhas will appear directly before them, and those blessed buddhas will say: 'Noble person, through hearing this great Dhāraṇī Sūtra teaching well proclaimed, you have generated this accumulation of merit.'

Those ninety-nine million blessed buddhas will also each prophesy in their own respective world-realms. So take heart and do not be afraid, for how much more is this so for one who has heard in full and at great length this entire vast compendium of Dharma of the Dhāraṇī Sūtra.'

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Sarvavikrāntagāmin, addressed the Blessed One with these words: 'Blessed One, if I too were to listen to this vast compendium of Dharma of the Dhāraṇī Sūtra, how great an accumulation of merit would I generate?'

The Blessed One declared: 'Sarvavikrāntagāmin, that sentient being would generate an accumulation of merit equal to the accumulation of merit of all the blessed buddhas as numerous as the grains of sand in the Ganges.'

Sarvavikrāntagāmin said: 'Blessed One, as for my hearing this vast compendium of Dharma of the Dhāraṇī Sūtra — Blessed One, I am never sated by it.'

The Blessed One declared: 'Sarvavikrāntagāmin, excellent, excellent! It is well that you are insatiable for the Dharma. Sarvavikrāntagāmin, even I myself am insatiable for the Dharma — how much more then could ordinary childish beings ever be expected to be sated by it?

Sarvavikrāntagāmin, whatever son of good family or daughter of good family generates faith in the Great Vehicle will not fall into wrong states of existence for a thousand eons, will not be born as an animal for five thousand eons, will not be born with a dull mind for twenty-two thousand eons, will not be born among peoples of the borderlands for eighty thousand eons, will be courageous in giving generously for twenty thousand eons, will be born in the realm of the gods for twenty-five thousand eons, and will lead a life of celibacy for thirty-five thousand eons. Thereafter, for forty thousand eons they will go forth from the household life. For fifty thousand eons they will uphold the Dharma. For sixty-five thousand eons they will cultivate the meditation on mindfulness of death.

Sarvavikrāntagāmin, not even the slightest non-virtuous action will arise in such a son or daughter of good family. The evil Māra will find no opportunity to seize upon them. They will never be born again in a mother's womb.

Sarvavikrāntagāmin, those who hear this compendium of Dharma, in whatever place they may be born, will not fall into wrong states of existence for ninety-five countless eons. For eighty thousand eons they will retain what they

have heard. For a thousand eons they will abandon the taking of life. For ninety-nine thousand eons they will abandon false speech. For thirteen thousand eons they will abandon divisive speech. Sarvavikrāntagāmin, sentient beings who hear this compendium of Dharma are rare indeed.'

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Sarvavikrāntagāmin, rose from his seat, arranged his upper robe over one shoulder, placed his right knee on the ground, joined his palms in homage toward the Blessed One, and addressed the Blessed One with these words: 'Blessed One, as for those who reject this compendium of Dharma — how great an accumulation of non-virtuous karma will they generate?'

The Blessed One declared: 'Sarvavikrāntagāmin, it will be vast.'

Sarvavikrāntagāmin asked: 'Blessed One, how vast an accumulation of non-virtuous karma will those sentient beings generate?'

The Blessed One declared: 'Sarvavikrāntagāmin, do not ask me all at once about the accumulation of non-virtuous karma.'

Sarvavikrāntagāmin, one who reviles even a single sūtra generates a far greater heap of non-virtue than one who arouses a thought of malice toward Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas as numerous as the grains of sand in twelve Ganges rivers. And those, Sarvavikrāntagāmin, who arouse a thought of harm toward the Great Vehicle will generate an even greater heap of non-virtue than that. Sarvavikrāntagāmin, those sentient beings are utterly burned up — burned up indeed.

Sarvavikrāntagāmin asked: 'Blessed One, is it not possible to liberate those sentient beings?'

The Blessed One declared: 'Sarvavikrāntagāmin, that is so — it is not possible to liberate them. Sarvavikrāntagāmin, consider this analogy: suppose a certain person has had his head cut off, and then honey, molasses, sugar, butter, sesame oil, or any ointment suitable for anointing is applied to that head. Sarvavikrāntagāmin, what do you think — could that sentient being rise again?'

Sarvavikrāntagāmin replied: 'Blessed One, there is no possibility of that.'

The Blessed One declared: 'Sarvavikrāntagāmin, yet consider another case: there is a certain other person who strikes another sentient being with a sharp weapon, and though a single blow is not enough to sever the life, Sarvavikrāntagāmin, a wound will arise. If medicine is applied, that wound will

heal. Once healed, the person, remembering the suffering, thinks: "Now I understand — henceforth I will never again engage in sinful, non-virtuous actions and will not accumulate them." In just that way, Sarvavikrāntagāmin, at the very moment that person remembers the suffering, he fully abandons all sin. At that time he will bring all phenomena directly into view, and having brought all phenomena directly into view, he will at that time fully perfect all virtuous phenomena.

Sarvavikrāntagāmin, consider this further analogy: just as a person who has died cannot be helped by parents who grieve and lament over him, in the same way, Sarvavikrāntagāmin, those sentient beings who are ordinary, childlike folk are unable to benefit either themselves or others. Just as those parents are cut off from hope, so too will those sentient beings be cut off from hope at the time of death.

Sarvavikrāntagāmin, these two things cut sentient beings off from hope. What are the two? This is to say: the first is a sentient being who commits sinful acts or induces others to commit them; the other is abandoning the sacred Dharma. These two are what cut sentient beings off from hope at the time of death.'

The bodhisattva Sarvavikrāntagāmin asked: 'Blessed One, what destiny will those sentient beings have? What will their next life be?'

The Blessed One declared: 'Sarvavikrāntagāmin, the destiny of those sentient beings who revile the sacred Dharma is without end, and their future lives too are without end. Sarvavikrāntagāmin, those sentient beings who abandon the sacred Dharma will, for an aeon, experience feelings in the great hell of Wailing. For an aeon in Crushing and Destroying; for an aeon in the Hot; for an aeon in the Intensely Hot; for an aeon in the great hell of Black Lines; for an aeon in the great hell of Avīci (the Unrelenting); for an aeon in the great hell called Hair-Raising; and for an aeon in the great hell called Kyi-hud — Sarvavikrāntagāmin, in those eight great hells they will experience suffering for eight aeons.'

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Sarvavikrāntagāmin, addressed the Blessed One with these words: 'Blessed One, this is suffering! O Sugata, this is suffering! I have no joy in hearing it.'

Then the Blessed One at that time spoke these verses:

How beings in the hells
intensely experience such suffering —
these words of great terror
you have no joy in hearing.

Whoever performs wholesome actions
will come to be in a state of good;
whoever performs unwholesome actions
will likewise come to be in a state of suffering.

One who does not know the cause of happiness,
bound by the suffering of grief
and the suffering of birth and death —
the childish are forever in suffering.

Those who keep constantly in mind the supreme buddha,
they who are wise are in a state of happiness;
those who have faith in the Great Vehicle
will not go to the lower destinies.

So too, Sarvavikrāntagāmin —
thoroughly urged on by former karma,
even a small action that is done
will yield inexhaustible fruit.

In the supremely excellent field of buddha-fields,
if a seed is planted, the fruit is great —
just as from planting a few seeds
one comes to enjoy abundant fruit.

Those who rejoice in the Victor's teaching,
they who are wise will come to be happy;
they abandon all negative deeds
and perform many wholesome ones.

Those who offer even a hair's-breadth of giving
to my teaching —
for eighty thousand aeons
they will have great enjoyment and abundant wealth;
and wherever they are reborn,
they will be ever endowed with generosity.
Such is the buddha-field of giving:

that profound one yields great fruit.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Sarvavikrāntagāmin, addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, how should I seek the Dharma as the Blessed One has taught it? Blessed One, how does one, upon hearing the categories of the Dharma of the Sūtra of Pairs, come to perfectly retain the roots of virtue?"

The Blessed One declared: "Sarvavikrāntagāmin, one should understand that whoever has paid homage and offered all the requisites of well-being to Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and completely awakened buddhas as numerous as the grains of sand of twelve Ganges rivers — the mass of merit from whoever hears these categories of the Dharma of the Sūtra of Pairs is to be understood as equal to that."

The bodhisattva Sarvavikrāntagāmin said: "Blessed One, how does one come to perfect the roots of virtue?"

When he had thus spoken, the Blessed One addressed the bodhisattva, the great being Sarvavikrāntagāmin, with these words: "Whatever those roots of virtue are, they should be understood as equal to a Tathāgata."

"Blessed One, what is the meaning of those roots of virtue being understood as equal to a Tathāgata?"

The Blessed One declared: "Sarvavikrāntagāmin, one who teaches the Dharma should be understood as equal to a Tathāgata."

Sarvavikrāntagāmin asked: "Blessed One, who is a teacher of Dharma?"

The Blessed One declared: "Whoever proclaims the Sūtra of Pairs — that one is a teacher of Dharma."

Sarvavikrāntagāmin said: "Blessed One, if those who merely hear the categories of the Dharma of the Sūtra of Pairs generate such a mass of merit, what need is there to speak of those who write it down and read it? What mass of merit will those ones generate?"

The Blessed One declared: "Sarvavikrāntagāmin, listen well. Consider this: in each of the four directions there abide, for twelve aeons, Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and completely awakened buddhas as numerous as the grains of sand of twelve Ganges rivers, and they teach the Dharma — yet even to attempt to describe the mass of merit from writing down this Sūtra of Pairs is

beyond the power of any comprehension or verbal expression. Even all the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, as numerous as the grains of sand of forty-eight Ganges rivers, could not express that mass of merit from writing it down — so what need is there to speak of those who write it down, contemplate it,

read it — how much more so those who read it and become a treasury of Dharma!

The bodhisattva Sarvāśūra asked: Blessed One, how great will the mass of merit from reading it be?

Then at that moment the Blessed One declared these verses:

The virtue of those who read
even a single verse of four lines —
the Victors as numerous as the grains of sand
of eighty-four Ganges rivers,
who have here read the Sūtra of Pairs,
even should they speak without ceasing
of whatever merit there may be from that,
that merit would never be exhausted.

The Dharma taught by the buddhas
is rare and without limit.

And at that very moment, eighty-four hundred billion gods, turning toward the place where the teaching of the categories of Dharma of the Sūtra of Pairs was being given, pressed their palms together, bowed, and addressed the Blessed One with these words: Blessed One, how excellent, how excellent, that the Blessed One has placed such a treasury of Dharma as this here in Jambudvīpa!

Then a different group of eighteen hundred billion naked ascetics (tīrthikas) came to where the Blessed One was and addressed him thus: Victory to the ascetic Gautama! The Blessed One declared: The Tathāgata is always victorious. You naked tīrthikas — how could you possibly be victorious? They said: Be victorious. May the ascetic Gautama be victorious. The Blessed One declared: I do not see any victory in you. You abide in confusion — how could you be victorious? You naked ones, listen, and I shall speak what is of benefit to you. There is no ease in a childish mind. How could you be victorious? With the eyes of a buddha I shall also teach you the profound path.

Then those naked ascetics became angry at the Blessed One and gave rise to a faithless mind. At that moment Śakra (Indra), lord of the gods, shook his

vajra, and those eighteen hundred billion naked ascetics, seized with terror and overcome with great suffering, wept and shed tears — and the Tathāgata also made his body invisible.

Then those naked ascetics, weeping, their faces filled with tears, not seeing the Blessed One, spoke these verses:

Here there is no ally, no companion.
Likewise there is no father, no mother.
It appears utterly like a desolate wilderness —
empty dwellings, no place of shelter.
Here there is no water,
no trees, no birds.
Here no person is to be seen.
Without a protector, we experience suffering;
not seeing the Tathāgata,
we suffer what is unbearable and great.

Then at that moment those eighteen hundred billion naked ascetics rose from their seats, placed both knees on the ground, and, crying out, made their appeal in song:

O Tathāgata, compassionate one,
perfectly awakened, supreme among the two-footed —
please act for our benefit!
We beseech you: protect these wretched beings!

Then the Blessed One smiled and said to the bodhisattva Sarvāśūra: Sarvāśūra, go and teach the Dharma to those other naked tīrthikas.

When the Blessed One had said this, the bodhisattva, the great being Sarvāśūra, said to the Blessed One: Blessed One, if Mount Kailāsa were to bow its peak toward the king of mountains, Mount Meru, without being pressed down upon it — in just the same way, how could I teach the Dharma while the Tathāgata himself is present?

The Blessed One declared: Kharoc, son of good family — go, and by the skillful means of the Tathāgatas, look throughout the world-realms of the ten directions at wherever Tathāgatas appear, and observe the seats upon which the Tathāgatas have settled —

"Sarvāśūra — I myself will teach the Dharma to those naked tīrthikas."

The bodhisattva Sarvāśūra said: "Blessed One, shall I go by my own miraculous power, or by the power of the Tathāgata's miraculous power, or by whose miraculous power shall I travel?"

The Blessed One declared: "Sarvāśūra, go by the blessing of your own miraculous power. Sarvāśūra, return by the power of the Tathāgata."

Then the bodhisattva Sarvāśūra rose from his seat, circumambulated the Blessed One, and vanished from that very spot.

Then the Blessed One taught the Dharma to those naked tīrthikas: "Friends, birth is suffering — birth itself is suffering. Once one is born, many terrors of suffering arise. Once one is born, the terrors of illness arise. From illness, the terrors of aging arise. From aging, the terrors of death arise."

"Blessed One, what is it that is called 'from birth, the terror of birth arises'? Once one is born as a human being, many terrors arise: the terror of kings arises, the terror of thieves arises, the terror of fire arises, the terror of poison arises, the terror of water arises, the terror of wind arises, the terror of whirlpools arises, and the terror of the karma one has created arises."

When the Blessed One had taught the Dharma in these and many other such aspects, taking birth as the topic, at that very time those naked tīrthikas were seized with great terror and said these words: "From this day forward, we shall never again delight in birth."

When the Blessed One taught this Dharma-enumeration of the Coupled Sūtras, those eighteen billion naked tīrthikas fully completed the unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. And from his own retinue, eighteen thousand bodhisattvas became firmly established on the ten grounds, and all of them displayed miraculous emanations such as these: the form of a horse, the form of an elephant, the form of a tiger, the form of a garuḍa, the form of Mount Meru, the form of a swastika-pattern, and some appeared in the form of wish-granting trees — and all of them were seated cross-legged on lotus thrones.

Nine billion bodhisattvas were arrayed on the Blessed One's right side, and nine billion bodhisattvas were arrayed on the Blessed One's left side. The Tathāgata remained ever in meditative equipoise, appearing to teach the Dharma through skillful means.

On the seventh day, the Tathāgata extended the palm of his hand, and through this the Blessed One knew that the bodhisattva, the great being

Sarvāśūra, was coming from the world-realm of Padmottara. The bodhisattva, the great being Sarvāśūra, had traveled to that world-realm of Padmottara by the blessing of his own miraculous power, and the journey there had taken seven days.

When the Blessed One extended his hand, at that very moment the bodhisattva Sarvāśūra was present before the Blessed One. He circumambulated the Blessed One three times, and then, with a concentrated mind, facing toward the Blessed One, he joined his palms and bowed, and spoke these words to the Blessed One:

"Blessed One, when I traveled to all the world-realms of the ten directions, with one miraculous feat I beheld nine billion nine hundred and ninety thousand buddha-fields, and with two miraculous feats I beheld ten billion Blessed Ones,

With the seventh miraculous feat I traveled to the world-realm of Padmottara, and along the way I beheld one hundred thousand billion immovable buddha-fields. Blessed One, from that point onward I beheld the miraculous feats of the Blessed Ones, the buddhas, and in ninety-two thousand billion buddha-fields I saw Tathāgatas teaching the Dharma. And under that same canopy, in eighty thousand billion buddha-fields, I beheld eighty thousand billion Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas who had appeared in the world. I paid homage to all those Tathāgatas, and then returned. Blessed One, under that same canopy, beyond thirty-nine thousand billion buddha-fields, in all those thirty-nine thousand billion buddha-fields, thirty-nine thousand billion bodhisattvas had arisen, and under that very canopy each had fully and perfectly awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Blessed One, I circumambulated those Tathāgatas, those arhats, those perfectly and fully awakened buddhas three times each, and then they vanished beyond the reach of miraculous power. Blessed One, in sixty billion buddha-fields as well I beheld Blessed Ones, buddhas. Blessed One, I paid homage to all those buddha-fields and all those Blessed Ones, the buddhas, and then came back. Blessed One, in another eighty billion buddha-fields I beheld Tathāgatas who were passing into complete nirvāṇa. I paid homage to those Tathāgatas as well, and then came back. Blessed One, furthermore, in ninety-five billion buddha-fields I witnessed the sacred Dharma falling into decline, and at that, Blessed One, a thought arose in me and I shed tears. I also witnessed many gods, nāgas, yakṣas, rākṣasas, and beings possessing form in the desire realm weeping and pierced by great pangs of

grief. Likewise, Blessed One, I witnessed other buddha-fields — complete with their oceans, their Mount Merus, and their every region of earth — consumed entirely in flames, and having paid homage there too, I came back in a state of utter despair. Blessed One, even before I had reached the world-realm of Padmottara, along the way I beheld five hundred thousand billion thrones set out for Blessed Ones — one hundred thousand billion thrones in the southern direction, one hundred thousand billion thrones in the northern direction, one hundred thousand billion thrones in the eastern direction, one hundred thousand billion thrones in the western direction, and one hundred thousand billion thrones in the direction above. Blessed One, all those thrones were made exclusively of the seven precious substances, and upon every one of those thrones a Tathāgata sat and taught the Dharma. Blessed One, I was filled with wonder at this, and I asked those Tathāgatas: "Blessed One, what is the name of this world-realm?" Those Tathāgatas declared: "Son of good family, this world-realm is called Padmottara." Blessed One, I then circumambulated those Tathāgatas, and asked them: "What is the name of the Tathāgata of this buddha-field?" They declared: "The Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and fully awakened buddha is called Padmagarbha, and he performs the work of a buddha in this buddha-field."

At that point I asked the following: "Even though there may be many tens of millions of Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas bearing the name Padmagarbha, which one is it that I have not yet found?" That Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, I have shown you the Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and fully awakened buddha named Padmagarbha."

Then the forms of all those Tathāgatas vanished, and there remained only the forms of bodhisattvas. A single Tathāgata remained, and I bowed my head at the feet of that Tathāgata and approached him, whereupon a throne appeared and I took my seat upon it. Then, Blessed One, many thrones appeared, and I saw that none had come to sit upon them. I said to that Tathāgata: "Blessed One, I see that no sentient being whatsoever has come to sit upon these thrones." That Blessed One declared: "Sentient beings who have not cultivated virtuous roots lack the power to sit upon these thrones."

I asked: "Blessed One, what virtuous roots must be cultivated in order for one to sit upon those thrones?" That Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, listen. Whatever sentient beings have heard the enumeration of Dharma teachings of the Paired Sūtra — by that virtuous root they will come to sit upon those thrones. And needless to say this applies to those who write it out and

read it aloud. It is because you, Sarvavikrāntin, heard the enumeration of Dharma teachings of the Paired Sūtra that you came to sit upon this throne; had that not been so, how could you have entered into this buddha-field?"

When that Blessed One had spoken thus, I said to that Blessed One: "Blessed One, how great a mass of merit does one generate by hearing this enumeration of Dharma teachings of the Paired Sūtra?"

At that, the Blessed One Padmagarbha, the Tathāgata, smiled. I asked that Blessed One why he smiled: "Blessed One, for what reason and on what account does the Tathāgata smile?" That Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, listen, for the bodhisattva, the great being Sarvavikrāntin, has attained great power. Consider this analogy: suppose someone were to become a wheel-turning king (cakravartin) ruling over the four continents, and were to sow sesame across the fields of all four continents. Sarvavikrāntin, what do you think — would many seeds grow?"

The bodhisattva Sarvavikrāntin replied: "Blessed One, they would be many. Sugata, they would be many."

The Blessed One declared: "Sarvavikrāntin, suppose then that some sentient being were to gather all those sesame seeds into a single heap, and another being were to take those sesame seeds one by one from that heap and set them down elsewhere. Sarvavikrāntin, what do you think — could that being count or measure those sesame seeds?"

The bodhisattva Sarvavikrāntin replied: "Blessed One, no. Sugata, no. There would be no way to count or measure those sesame seeds."

"Sarvavikrāntin, in just the same way, the mass of merit arising from the enumeration of Dharma teachings of the Paired Sūtra cannot be measured by anyone other than a Tathāgata. Sarvavikrāntin, consider further: suppose there were as many Tathāgatas as there are sesame seeds, and all of them together were to fully proclaim the merit arising from the virtuous root of hearing the Dharma enumeration of the Paired teachings — and even then, even with the aid of such analogies, that merit would not be exhausted. How much more so, then, is this the case for one who writes it out, reads it aloud, and has others write it out!"

The bodhisattva Sarvavikrāntin asked: "Blessed One, how great a store of merit does writing it out produce?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, listen. Consider all the grasses and trees of the great trichiliocosm cut down to pieces of one finger-breadth each — that is one analogy. Now, Sarvavikrāntin, hear a second: consider all the rocks, ravines, earth, and finest dust particles of the great trichiliocosm — as many as there are of them — and suppose each became a wheel-turning king (cakravartin) reigning over the four continents. Could the merit of all those kings be measured?"

Sarvavikrāntin replied: "Blessed One, it could not — none but a Tathāgata could measure it."

"Just so, Sarvavikrāntin, the mass of merit from writing out the Dharma enumeration of the Paired Sūtra likewise cannot be measured. Indeed, one who writes down even a single syllable of this Dharma enumeration generates a mass of merit far greater than the combined merit of however many wheel-turning kings there may be — for those kings, with all their abundant merit, are not equal to it.

"In the same way, Sarvavikrāntin, the merit of a great bodhisattva who upholds and practices the sacred Dharma of the Great Vehicle cannot be surpassed by any wheel-turning king. And likewise, the mass of merit from writing out the Dharma enumeration of the Paired Sūtra cannot be measured by any such comparison.

"Sarvavikrāntin, this Paired Sūtra is a revealer of treasure-stores of merit. It pacifies all mental afflictions. It causes the lamp of all phenomena to blaze brightly. It defeats every wicked māra. It causes the abode of every bodhisattva to blaze with radiance. It fully accomplishes the accomplishment of all phenomena."

When this had been declared, the great bodhisattva Sarvavikrāntin spoke to the Blessed One thus: "Blessed One, the holy life (brahmacarya) practiced here is an exceedingly difficult practice. Why so? Because, Blessed One, the conduct of a Tathāgata is rare, and in just the same way the holy life too is rare. When one practices the holy life, one comes to behold a Tathāgata directly — one comes to see a Tathāgata day and night. When one directly beholds a Tathāgata and gazes upon a Tathāgata day and night, one sees a buddha-field. When one sees a buddha-field, one sees every treasure within it. At the moment of one's death, no fear will arise. Never again will one be born in a mother's womb. Never again will one be a being of sorrow. Never again will one be bound by the snare of craving."

When this had been said, the Blessed One spoke thus to the great bodhisattva Sarvavikrāntin: "Sarvavikrāntin, the arising of Tathāgatas is rare and hard to find."

Sarvavikrāntin replied: "Blessed One, it is rare and hard to find. O Sugata, it is rare and hard to find."

The Blessed One declared: "Sarvavikrāntin, in just the same way this Dharma enumeration of the Paired Sūtra is likewise rare and hard to find. Sarvavikrāntin, whoever hears this Dharma enumeration of the Paired teaching resounding in their ear will, for eighty aeons, remember their past lives."

For sixty thousand aeons one will attain the status of a wheel-turning king. For eight thousand aeons one will attain the status of Śakra (Indra, king of the gods). For twenty thousand aeons one will be born with a share of fortune equal to the gods of the Pure Abodes. For thirty-eight thousand aeons one will become a great Brahmā. For ninety-nine thousand aeons one will not fall into a lower rebirth. For one hundred thousand aeons one will not be born among hungry ghosts (pretas). For twenty-eight thousand aeons one will not be born among animals. For thirteen thousand aeons one will not be born in the class of asuras. One will not die by the sword. For twenty-five thousand aeons one will not come to have impaired wisdom. For seven thousand aeons one will come to practise wisdom. For nine thousand aeons one will be beautiful and lovely to behold, perfectly endowed with a form body like that of a Tathāgata. For fifteen thousand aeons one will not be born as a woman. For sixteen thousand aeons one will not be afflicted by bodily illness. For thirty-five thousand aeons one will come to possess the divine eye. For nineteen thousand aeons one will not be born in nāga realms of rebirth. For sixty thousand aeons one will not be overpowered by the force of anger. For seven thousand aeons one will not be born in a household of poverty. For eighty thousand aeons one will come to enjoy both continents, and even when poverty does befall one, one will still attain just such happiness as this. For twelve thousand aeons one will not be born in a state of blindness. For thirteen thousand aeons one will not be born in the lower realms. For eleven thousand aeons one will speak with patience. And at the time of death, when the final moment of consciousness ceases, one's perceptions will not be distorted, and one will not be overpowered by anger. At that moment one will directly behold, in the eastern direction, as many blessed buddhas as there are grains of sand in twelve Ganges rivers. In the southern direction one will directly behold as

many blessed buddhas as there are grains of sand in twenty koṭis of Ganges rivers. In the western direction one will directly behold as many blessed buddhas as there are grains of sand in twenty-five Ganges rivers. In the northern direction one will directly behold as many blessed buddhas as there are grains of sand in eighty Ganges rivers. In the direction above one will directly behold ninety thousand koṭis of blessed buddhas. In the direction below one will directly behold as many blessed buddhas as there are grains of sand in one hundred koṭis of Ganges rivers. And all of those, addressing that son of good family, will offer this encouragement: "Son of good family, because you have heard this Dharma enumeration of the Paired teaching, you will come to possess in future lives qualities and benefits and happiness of just this measure — have no fear!"

"Noble son, do you see all those Tathāgatas — as many as grains of sand in countless hundreds of thousands of koṭis of Ganges rivers?"

Sarvavikrāntin replied: "Blessed One, I see them. O Sugata, I see them."

The Blessed One declared: "Noble son, those Tathāgatas have come to look upon you."

Sarvavikrāntin replied: "What wholesome action have I performed that so many Tathāgatas should come to where I am?"

The Blessed One declared: "Noble son, listen well."

"Because you obtained a human body and heard this teaching of the Paired Sūtra with your own ears, a mass of merit of just that measure has arisen for you."

Sarvavikrāntin replied: "Blessed One, if my mass of merit has grown to that measure merely from hearing it, what need is there to speak of hearing it in its entirety and with full comprehension?"

The Blessed One declared: "Excellent! Excellent! Noble son, listen now — I shall speak of the merit of a single four-line verse. Noble son, consider this example: even greater than the mass of merit accumulated by Tathāgatas — arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas — as numerous as the grains of sand in thirteen Ganges rivers would be the mass of merit accumulated by one who hears even a single four-line verse from this Paired Sūtra. And if merely hearing a single four-line verse produces a mass of merit greater than making offerings to Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas as numerous as the grains of sand in thirteen Ganges rivers, what need is there

to speak of hearing it in its entirety and with full comprehension?

"Noble son, now listen to the merit of one who hears this Paired Sūtra in its entirety and with full comprehension. Suppose that throughout the entire world-system of a great three-thousand-fold universe every sesame seed that could be packed in were planted, and there were that many wheel-turning kings. Then suppose there were a certain man of wealth, with great possessions and abundant riches, and he gave gifts to all those wheel-turning kings. Yet the mass of merit produced by giving to a single stream-enterer (srotāpanna) surpasses even that.

"Suppose all the sentient beings of the great three-thousand-fold universe became stream-enterers, and someone gave gifts to every single one of them. Yet the mass of merit produced by giving to a single once-returner (sakṛdāgāmin) surpasses even that.

"Suppose all the sentient beings of the great three-thousand-fold universe became once-returners, and someone gave gifts to every single one of them. Yet the mass of merit produced by giving to a single non-returner (anāgāmin) surpasses even that.

"Suppose all the sentient beings of the great three-thousand-fold universe became non-returners, and someone gave gifts to every single one of them. Yet the mass of merit produced by giving to a single arhat surpasses even that.

"Suppose all the sentient beings of the great three-thousand-fold universe became arhats, and someone gave gifts to every single one of them. Yet the mass of merit produced by giving to a single pratyekabuddha surpasses even that.

"Suppose all the sentient beings of the great three-thousand-fold universe became pratyekabuddhas, and someone gave gifts to every single one of them. Yet the mass of merit produced by giving to a single bodhisattva surpasses even that.

"Suppose all the sentient beings of the great three-thousand-fold universe became bodhisattvas, and someone gave gifts to every single one of them. Yet the mass of merit produced by one who generates a mind of faith toward even a single Tathāgata — and by one who generates a mind of faith toward Tathāgatas filling that entire great three-thousand-fold world-system —"

One who merely hears this enumeration of Dharma teachings from the paired sūtra will produce a mass of merit far greater than all of that. What need is there, then, to speak of Sarvashūra who writes down, retains, recites, and masters this enumeration of Dharma teachings? And what need is there even to speak of Sarvashūra who bows down with a devoted mind toward this enumeration of Dharma teachings?

Sarvashūra, what do you think? Are all ordinary childlike beings capable of hearing this?

Even those who do hear it will not generate faith.

Sarvashūra, listen. Among sentient beings who are ordinary childlike beings, is there any who is able to fathom the depths of the great ocean?

The reply came: Blessed One, there is not.

The Blessed One declared: Sarvashūra, is there any sentient being who can drain the ocean with a single palm of the hand?

The reply came: Blessed One, there is not. Sugata, there is not.

The Blessed One declared: Sarvashūra, just as there is no sentient being capable of drying up the great ocean, so too there is no sentient being whose inclination is toward the lesser who can listen to this enumeration of Dharma teachings. Sarvashūra, those who have not seen Tathāgatas as numerous as the grains of sand of eighty Ganges rivers multiplied by ten million are not able to write down this enumeration of Dharma teachings from the paired sūtra. Those who have seen Tathāgatas as numerous as the grains of sand of ninety Ganges rivers are not able to listen to this enumeration of Dharma teachings. Those who have not seen Tathāgatas numbering one hundred thousand million will, upon hearing this enumeration of Dharma teachings, turn away from it and abandon it. Sarvashūra, those who have seen Tathāgatas as numerous as the grains of sand of one hundred million Ganges rivers — upon hearing this enumeration of Dharma teachings, they will generate a devoted mind, they will rejoice, they will come to know it just as it is in its entirety, and they will have faith in this enumeration of Dharma teachings from the paired sūtra and will not abandon it.

Sarvashūra, listen. Whoever writes down even a single four-line verse from this paired sūtra — for those beings, ninety-five thousand million world-systems will be transcended, and the buddha-field of those beings will become just like the world-system of Sukhāvatī. Sarvashūra, the lifespan of

those sentient beings will be capable of enduring for eighty-four thousand aeons.

Sarvashūra, listen. Bodhisattvas, great beings, who have heard even just a single four-line verse from this enumeration of Dharma teachings of the paired sūtra — it is like this, Sarvashūra: a sentient being who has committed, caused others to commit, or rejoiced in the committing of the five actions of immediate retribution, if that being hears even a single four-line verse from this enumeration of Dharma teachings of the paired sūtra, those five sinful actions of immediate retribution will be purified.

The Second Fascicle.

Sarvashūra, listen — other qualities too shall be explained. It is like this: consider a sentient being who has destroyed a stūpa, created a schism in the Saṅgha, distracted a bodhisattva from meditative absorption, obstructed the arising of a buddha's wisdom, and taken a human life. Such a being later comes to feel remorse and grief, thinking: "By this body I have ruined myself. I am ruined in the world beyond as well. I am unworthy." A great sense of that unworthiness arises, and such a being experiences feelings of suffering, experiences feelings of unbearable pain. Sarvashūra, that sentient being will be abandoned by all sentient beings. They will be reviled. That sentient being is scorched, rendered unfit — having made themselves unfit for both worldly and transmundane Dharma.

Just as a burnt tree-stump remains as it is for many aeons, so too will that person remain in such a state. Just as a well-painted house becomes ugly when its main beam is charred, so too will that person become. Even in this world he will be without beauty. Wherever he goes, sentient beings will revile and beat him, and he will be threatened by hunger and thirst, and will find even the slightest thing to be of no avail. Because of this he will experience feelings of suffering, threatened by hunger and thirst, by the causes of being reviled, and recalling that he has destroyed a stūpa and committed the five acts of immediate retribution, he will think: "Where shall I go? Who is my protector?" A mind weary of suffering will arise in him, and he will think to himself: "Here there is no one to protect me. I shall go into the mountains and ravines and there bring about my death."

He speaks:

"Because I have committed evil acts,
I am always like a charred tree-stump.

In this world I am without beauty,
and in the next life I will not be beautiful either.
Neither within the house am I pleasing,
nor outside it either.
Through the cause of wrongdoing I have done evil,
and by that I shall go to the lower realms.
In the next life I will be in suffering —
in these lower realms, where shall I abide?
Weeping, my eyes filled with tears, I cry out aloud,
and even the gods hear my words.
Alas! In the world beyond,
going to the lower realms, my hopes are shattered."

The gods then spoke to him:

"Foolish man, let go of that
mind of suffering, and leave off.
You slew your father and slew your mother;
I committed the five acts of immediate retribution.
I have no refuge, no ally.
I will experience feelings of suffering.
Going to a mountain peak,
I shall then cast this body away."

"Foolish man, do not go!
With a mind intent on harm,
you have committed many evil acts —
do not commit such evil actions.
Those who harm me
will go in suffering to the hells.
By weeping and lamenting,
one only ends up falling to the ground.
With such diligence one will not become a buddha;
nor will one become a bodhisattva.
One will not attain even the vehicle of liberation of a śrāvaka —
therefore strive with a different kind of diligence.
Go to that mountain where the great sages dwell.
Having gone and encountered a great sage,
bow down to his feet, head to the ground, and say:

'Venerable being, grant me your protection!
I am utterly tormented by fearful suffering.
Noble sentient being, sage, please speak a living word!
Remain, and open to me the opportunity of mind.
For even a moment, speak to me of virtuous Dharma.
Tormented and afflicted by terror and suffering,
therefore I beg you: remain for just a moment.
I wish to confess the many evils I have done.
May the sage bestow his word upon me.'"

The sage spoke:

"Tormented by weeping, grief, and sorrow,
you are threatened by hunger and thirst.
Since you are in despair and are going to the three realms of existence,
eat the food that has been given.
In order to satisfy the body,
the sage gave him food.
Having eaten the delicious and pleasant food,
the sentient being became greatly joyful.
The Dharma that purifies all evil
I will explain to you afterwards."

That delicious food was eaten in a single instant. After eating, he washed his hands, circumambulated the sage, sat down cross-legged, and spoke of each and every evil he had done. He said: "I slew my father, and I slew my mother. I destroyed a stūpa. And I obstructed the attainment of awakening by a bodhisattva." Having heard those words, the sage then spoke:

"Because you have committed evil acts —
alas, O man, you are without virtue!"

"Confess the evil acts that you have done
and the evil acts you have caused others to do."

Then, in that very moment, he was pierced by the thorn of grief, and in fear and anguish he cried out:

"Who will protect me?
For I have done evil acts,
and I shall experience the feeling of suffering."

Then that man placed both his knees on the ground and said to the sage:

"All the evil I have done and caused others to do
I confess in full.

May I not meet the fruit of evil;
may I not experience suffering.

Let me draw near to you —

O sage, be my refuge.

Through remorse and through the peace it brings,
may my evil acts be calmed."

Then, in that very moment, the sage spoke to that man:

"I will be your refuge, O man. I will be your support. I will be your ally. Have no fear — listen to the Dharma directly. Have you ever heard even a little of the teaching called 'Comprehension'?" After he had breathed out these words, the man replied: "I have not heard it." The sage said: "Who but one who abides in compassion and teaches the Dharma to sentient beings would teach the Dharma to a being scorched by affliction?" Then he spoke: "O son of good family, listen further.

"Long, long ago, in the past, in a time beyond innumerable kalpas — beyond even the most innumerable — there was at that time a king named Stainless Moon, a Dharmic king, a king of Dharma. O son of good family, in the household of King Stainless Moon a son was born. The great king Stainless Moon then gathered together brahmin astrologers and asked them: 'What marks do you observe in this young boy?' The brahmin astrologers replied: 'Great King, this is inauspicious. The birth of this boy is inauspicious.' The king asked: 'What will this brahmin boy become?' The astrologers replied: 'Great King, if this boy survives to the age of seven, he will take the lives of his father and mother.' The king then said: 'Even if it means an obstruction to my own life, I will not kill this son of mine. In a hundred lives taken as a human being in this world, to harm a human body in such a way — this I will not do.' Then the boy grew with remarkable speed, such that when one month had passed he measured as much as another child two years old. King Stainless Moon recognized that this boy had been born through the accumulation of his own karma. The king then granted the boy royal authority and spoke these words: 'You shall become a king of great power and renown — rule by Dharma, and not by what is contrary to Dharma.' Having granted him royal authority, he gave him the title of king. Yet King Stainless Moon himself would no longer rule

as king of his own realm. Then his ministers by the tens of millions went to where King Stainless Moon was, came before him, and spoke to him thus: 'O great king, why will you not be king of your own realm?' The king replied: 'Throughout countless innumerable kalpas, whenever I have had dominion over kingship, wealth, and power, I have never once felt satisfied.' Then, after a long time had passed, that son killed both his father and mother, and thereby he accumulated an act of immediate retribution.

"O man, at that time when that king, feeling the sensation of suffering, fell into remorse and wept with tears streaming down his face, I arose in him great compassion, went to him, and taught him the Dharma —

He too, upon hearing that Dharma teaching, I recall, was the occasion when all the remaining acts of immediate retribution were swiftly and completely purified.

Then he spoke: "Whoever hears this King of Sūtras known as the Coupled Synonyms of Dharma, through this great ascetic practice, will attain the supreme Dharma-ground (sthāna) — the purification of all misdeeds and the pacification of all afflictions."

Whoever quickly gains liberation —
hear this well, the teaching of all phenomena:
even a single verse of four lines,
spoken in an unbroken stream —
all misdeeds are thereby purified,
and the entry into the stream is attained.
Freed from every misdeed —
this is the solemn declaration, the solemn declaration.
From the bonds of fear binding mind to hell,
the suffering of sentient beings is utterly released.

Then that man rose from his seat, joined his palms together, bowed his head in homage to him, and gave praise, saying: "Excellent! Excellent, O virtuous spiritual friend! Excellent, O destroyer of misdeeds! Excellent too are those who will hear the great Coupled Sūtra that has been taught!"

Then at that very time and moment, two thousand sons of the gods descended from the sky, joined their palms together, went before that ascetic, bowed at his feet, and spoke these words: "Blessed One, engaged in great austerity — how much longer is this still needed?" The ascetic replied: "For countless innumerable myriads of hundreds of thousands of kalpas." They asked:

"Through what wholesome act will these evil karmas be completely pacified in a single instant?" He replied: "By hearing the Coupled Synonyms of Dharma."

Of all those sentient beings assembled there, each and every one who heard this synonymy of Dharma and gave rise to faith received the prophecy of unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening.

As for any person who has committed the five acts of immediate retribution — if they hear this synonymy of Dharma called the Coupled, then in a single instant all five of those acts of immediate retribution will be completely exhausted and utterly purified, and for countless myriads of hundreds of thousands of kalpas the doors to the lower destinies will be closed. And the thirty-two doors to the heavenly worlds will be thrown open.

If even hearing just a single verse of four lines from this synonymy of Dharma called the Coupled can generate a root of virtue of such magnitude, what need is there to speak of one who honors, reveres, depicts, venerates, and performs acts of service to it with flowers, incense, perfume, garlands, ointment, powder, Dharma-robos, parasols, victory banners, and pennants — accompanied by music and instruments — and who, again and again rejoicing after each act, praises it well and says "Excellent! Excellent!"?

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Sarvasūra addressed the Blessed One thus: "Blessed One, when the Coupled Synonyms of Dharma is being expounded, do those who join their palms together and bow in homage — do they generate a mass of merit by that gesture of joining palms alone?"

The Blessed One declared: "Listen well, son of good family. Even those who have themselves committed, caused others to commit, or rejoiced in the commission of the five acts of immediate retribution — if they hear even a single verse of four lines from this synonymy of Dharma called the Coupled, and then join their palms together and bow in homage, all five of their acts of immediate retribution will be completely purified. What then need be said, Sarvasūra, of one who hears this entire synonymy of Dharma in full?"

That generates an even vaster mass of merit than all of that. Son of good family, so that you may understand the meaning of this synonymy of Dharma called the Coupled, I shall set forth a simile for you, Sarvasūra. Consider this: from the palace of Anavapta, the king of nāgas, where the sun never rises, five great rivers flow forth. Now, if someone were to count the drops of those five great rivers, Sarvasūra — could they, by counting those drops, arrive at a reckoning of their limit?

Sarvasūra replied: "Blessed One, that would be inconceivable."

The Blessed One declared: "Just so, Sarvasūra, the roots of virtue from this synonymy of Dharma called the Coupled cannot be reckoned to their limit even if one were to count for a hundred aeons or even for a thousand aeons. Sarvasūra, what do you think? Is it a difficult thing to teach even a brief portion of this synonymy of Dharma called the Coupled?"

He replied: "Blessed One, it is indeed a difficult thing."

The Blessed One declared: "Sarvasūra, one who is able to teach this synonymy of Dharma called the Coupled performs something more difficult still. For consider this simile: the drops of those five great rivers that flow from Lake Anavapta cannot be reckoned to their limit by counting."

Sarvasūra asked: "Blessed One, which are those five great rivers?"

The Blessed One declared: "They are as follows: the Gaṅgā, the Sītā, the Vakṣu, the Yamunā, and the Candrabhāgā — those are the five great rivers, and they all flow into the great ocean. Each of the great rivers, moreover, has five hundred tributary rivers. Sarvasūra, those five great rivers also have a thousand tributaries each, and they descend from the sky, and by them all living beings are satisfied. Sarvasūra, further, at various times those rivers send forth continuous streams of raindrops, and from them flowers, fruits, and harvests are born. Whenever continuous rain falls upon Jambudvīpa, water arises; and when water arises it satisfies all fields and pleasure groves and brings happiness. Sarvasūra, consider this simile: just so the lord of creatures brings happiness to all of Jambudvīpa. Sarvasūra, in the same way this synonymy of Dharma called the Coupled is also taught in Jambudvīpa for the benefit of many beings and for the happiness of many beings.

The measure of the lifespan of the gods of the Thirty-Three is not the same as the measure of the lifespan of humans. Sarvasūra, who are the gods of the Thirty-Three? Those who dwell where Śakra, the lord of the gods (Indra), resides — those are called the Thirty-Three.

Sarvasūra, there are sentient beings who speak words of good conduct, and the mass of merit of those beings defies all comparison. There are also sentient beings who speak words of harmful conduct, and the extent to which those beings shall fall into the hells and among the animals likewise defies all comparison. As for those sentient beings who are to experience the suffering of the hells, of animals, and of hungry ghosts — there is for them no refuge

whatsoever.

Those who at that point are cut off from hope, lamenting and wailing as they fall into the hells — those beings are to be understood as being under the power of unwholesome companions. And those sentient beings whose mass of merit from speaking words of good conduct defies all comparison — those likewise are to be understood as being under the power of a spiritual friend. For whenever one sees a spiritual friend, one thereby sees a Tathāgata. And whenever one sees a Tathāgata, all sins are thereby purified. And whenever the Lord of Creatures rejoices in Jambudvīpa, the happiness of the sentient beings of Jambudvīpa defies all comparison.

Sarvasūra, in just the same way, this enumeration of the teachings of Zuñ also performs the work of a buddha for the sentient beings of Jambudvīpa. Those who do not come to hear this enumeration of the teachings of Zuñ will be unable to fully awaken to the highest, perfect, and complete awakening; unable to turn the wheel of Dharma; unable to strike the Dharma gong; unable to take their seat on the lion throne of Dharma; unable to enter into the expanse of nirvāṇa; and unable to illuminate with immeasurable rays of light. Sarvasūra, in just the same way, those who do not come to hear this enumeration of the teachings of Zuñ will also be unable to sit at the seat of awakening.

Sarvasūra then asked: Blessed One, I wish to ask something wonderful. Sugata, I wish to ask something wonderful.

The Blessed One declared: Sarvasūra, ask whatever you wish, and I shall resolve your doubts.

He asked: Who is it that, having fully liberated those sentient beings from the five acts of immediate retribution and established them one by one on the stage of non-return, came to be the sage?

The Blessed One declared:

The words of the buddhas are profound.

Sarvasūra, listen to me.

The one who teaches the sūtra of Zuñ
is revealed in the form of a sage.

Zuñ also fully reveals the bodies of the buddhas
for the sake of loving affection.

Zuñ reveals forms as numerous

as the grains of sand in the Ganges.
Revealing the form of a buddha,
and fully teaching the Dharma itself —
whoever wishes to behold a buddha:
Zuñ is the equal of a buddha.
Wherever Zuñ is present,
a buddha is forever present there.

The Blessed One then declared: Son of good family, listen. Sarvasūra, in the past, in an age gone by, ninety-nine immeasurable kalpas ago, one hundred and twenty billion buddhas appeared. Among them there appeared a Tathāgata called Supreme Jewel. At that time I was bold in generosity, and I paid homage and offered service to one hundred and twenty billion buddhas called Moonlike, with food and drink, clothing, incense, garlands, unguents, whatever was conducive to ease, fine food, and all articles of comfort. Having rendered that service, I recall there hearing the prophecy of the highest, perfect, and complete awakening being given at that occasion.

Sarvasūra, I also recall one hundred and eighty billion Tathāgatas called Illuminator of All Precious Things having appeared. At that time too I was bold in generosity, and I paid individual, lavish homage and offered service to one hundred and eighty billion Tathāgatas called Essence of the Multitude — with incense, garlands, unguents, ornaments, and abundance of every suitable kind — and I recall there too hearing the prophecy of the highest, perfect, and complete awakening being given.

Sarvasūra, I recall two hundred billion buddhas — among them the Tathāgata, the arhat, the fully and perfectly awakened one called Source of the Topknot, and those alone.

Sarvasūra, I recall twenty billion buddhas — among them the Tathāgata, the arhat, the fully and perfectly awakened one called Protector of Light, and those alone. There too I was bold in generosity, and I paid homage to those Tathāgatas with incense, garlands, and unguents, and I rendered them whatever service and attendance is fitting to offer Tathāgatas — and by means of such service and attendance I there too received the prophecy of the highest, perfect, and complete awakening.

Sarvasūra, sixteen billion buddhas called Stainless Light appeared in the world. At that time I was a householder, wealthy and possessing great riches

and abundant resources, one who gave away all his possessions entirely. I offered to all sixteen billion of those buddhas food and drink, incense, garlands, unguents, and canopies, paying them homage in whatever manner is fitting as service and attendance to Tathāgatas — and I recall that there too I received the prophecy of the highest, perfect, and complete awakening. As for the time and measure of that prophecy, it does not fall within my reckoning.

Sarvasūra, listen well. Ninety-five billion buddhas appeared in the world, every one of them the Tathāgata, the arhat, the fully and perfectly awakened one called Śākyamuni. At that time I was a righteous king, a dharma-king, and I paid homage to all ninety-five billion of those Tathāgatas called Śākyamuni with incense, garlands, unguents, food and drink, clothing, parasols, victory banners, and pennants — and I recall that there too I received the prophecy of the highest, perfect, and complete awakening.

Sarvasūra, ninety billion Tathāgatas, arhats, fully and perfectly awakened buddhas called Destroyer of Cyclic Existence appeared in the world. At that time I was a young brahmin, wealthy, possessing great riches and abundant resources, one who gave away all his possessions entirely. I paid homage to all those Tathāgatas with incense, garlands, unguents, food and drink, and clothing, and I rendered each of those Tathāgatas individual and fitting service — and I recall that there too I received the prophecy of the highest, perfect, and complete awakening. As for the time and measure of that prophecy, it does not fall within my reckoning.

Sarvasūra, one hundred and eighty billion buddhas appeared in the world, every one of them the Tathāgata, the arhat, the fully and perfectly awakened one called Golden Sage. At that time I was bold in generosity, and I paid homage to those Tathāgatas, those arhats, those fully and perfectly awakened buddhas, with incense, garlands, unguents, food and drink, clothing, and ornaments, and I rendered them service in whatever manner is fitting as attendance to Tathāgatas — and I recall that there too I received the prophecy of the highest, perfect, and complete awakening. As for the time and measure of that prophecy, it does not fall within my reckoning.

Sarvasūra, one hundred and thirty billion buddhas appeared in the world, every one of them the Tathāgata, the arhat, the fully and perfectly awakened one called Splendor of Illumination. I paid homage to those Tathāgatas, those arhats, those fully and perfectly awakened buddhas, with food and drink,

clothing, incense, garlands, unguents, canopies, and ornaments, rendering them the service and attendance that is fitting to offer Tathāgatas, and by means of such service and attendance —

those Tathāgatas as well taught me various Dharma gates (sūtra) of meaning and definitive discipline, and right there I received the prophecy of unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening. Yet even then the time appointed for that prophecy had not arrived.

Sarvasūra, twenty-five billion Tathāgatas, arhats, fully and perfectly awakened buddhas called Victorious Star appeared in the world. At that time I had gone forth and rendered service and attendance to those Tathāgatas, just as Ānanda now renders service and attendance to me. In that very way I rendered service and attendance to those Tathāgatas, and I recall receiving there the prophecy of unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening — yet even then the time appointed for that prophecy had not arrived.

Sarvasūra, twelve billion Tathāgatas, arhats, fully and perfectly awakened buddhas called All-Seeing appeared in the world. I rendered service and attendance to those Tathāgatas with food and drink, clothing, incense, garlands, and unguents, serving them in the way fitting to offer Tathāgatas. At that time I had gone forth, and right there I received the prophecy of unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening — I recall this. And before long, the last of those All-Seeing Tathāgatas to appear taught this enumeration of the Dharma called Paired Categories. Upon learning of it, I then caused a rain of the seven precious substances to fall abundantly over Jambudvīpa, so that the sentient beings of Jambudvīpa were freed from poverty. Right there I received the prophecy of unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening. Yet for a long stretch of time thereafter I still received no prophecy.

He asked: What was that time? What was its measure?

The Blessed One declared: Sarvasūra, listen well. After an incalculable number of aeons, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the fully and perfectly awakened buddha called Dīpaṃkara (the Lamp-Maker) first appeared in the world. At that time and in that age I was a young brahmin boy named Megha (Cloud). When the Tathāgata Dīpaṃkara appeared in the world, I, in the form of that young brahmin boy, was practicing the holy life. Then, upon beholding the Tathāgata Dīpaṃkara, I scattered seven blue lotus flowers before him and dedicated them to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening. That Tathāgata then prophesied to me: Young brahmin boy, in a future time, after incalculable

aeons, you will become a Tathāgata, an arhat, a fully and perfectly awakened buddha known as Śākyamuni.

Sarvasūra, at that moment I was seated in the sky above the tops of twelve palm trees and had attained the acceptance of non-arising dharmas (anutpattikadharmakṣānti). All the roots of virtue I had cultivated through the holy life over those incalculable aeons, and all the roots of virtue endowed with the perfections — I recalled all of these as vividly as if they were yesterday and today.

Sarvasūra, had I at that moment established countless billions of sentient beings in wholesome dharmas, what need is there to speak of my desire, now that I have fully and perfectly awakened to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening, to bring benefit to all sentient beings?

Sarvasūra, I have taught sentient beings the Dharma in many forms. According to whatever form is fitting to tame a given being, in just such a form I have taught that being the Dharma.

In the world of the gods, I taught the Dharma in the form of a god. In the realm of the nāgas, I taught the Dharma in the form of a nāga. In the realm of the yakṣas, I taught the Dharma in the form of a yakṣa. In the realm of the hungry ghosts, I taught the Dharma in the form of a hungry ghost. In the human world, I taught the Dharma in the form of a human. To sentient beings to be tamed by a buddha, I taught the Dharma in the form of a buddha. To sentient beings to be tamed by a bodhisattva, I taught the Dharma in the form of a bodhisattva. Whatever form would tame sentient beings, in just that form I taught them the Dharma. Thus, Sarvasūra, I have taught the Dharma to sentient beings in many forms.

Why is this so? Sarvasūra, to the extent that sentient beings hear the Dharma in its many forms, those beings, in their very essence, will cultivate roots of virtue in many forms: they will practice generosity, they will accumulate merit, they will not lie down in pursuit of their own benefit alone, they will contemplate mindfulness of death, and they will perform virtuous deeds of that kind, gathered together. Through their having heard the Dharma, they will come to recall earlier roots of virtue, and those gods and humans will thereby come to have long-term welfare, benefit, and happiness.

Thus, Sarvasūra, as soon as the enumeration of the coupled Dharma is heard, its qualities and benefits become immeasurable in just that way.

Then those sentient beings said one to another: "May there be some other ripened fruit of wholesome dharmas — the maturation of the fruit of one who has fully and perfectly awakened to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening through what has been done and accumulated, and who wishes to bring benefit to all sentient beings!"

Then those among them who had faith in the Dharma and said truly and correctly, "The Dharma exists," — for them the great ripened fruit of well-being will be the unsurpassable happiness of the Dharma.

As for those deluded and foolish sentient beings who say, "These dharmas do not exist; there is no going to the further shore of the dharmas" — for them the great ripened fruit will be rebirth in the lower realms. Again and again they will incline toward the ground of lower rebirths. For eight aeons they will experience the feelings of suffering in the hells. For twelve aeons they will experience feelings of suffering in the realms of hungry ghosts. For sixteen aeons they will be born among the asuras. For nine thousand aeons they will be born among spirits and flesh-eaters. For forty thousand aeons they will be without a tongue. For sixty thousand aeons they will die in their mother's womb. For twenty thousand aeons they will be reduced to lumps of flesh. For eleven thousand aeons they will be born blind and experience feelings of suffering — and at that time their parents will think: "We have experienced suffering to no purpose. The birth of our child was pointless. We carried it in the womb for nine months to no purpose. We experienced the sensations of cold and heat. We fully experienced the suffering of hunger and thirst. In this life too we experienced so much suffering." When the parents see the blind child in the home, it will bring them no joy, and the parents will come to despair completely.

Sarvaśūra, likewise, sentient beings who abandon the sacred Dharma are inclined toward the hell realms and the animal realm. At the time of their death they will be pierced by a great arrow of grief and sorrow.

Sarvaśūra, those who say such things as "phenomena exist" and "there is a going beyond phenomena" — through that root of virtue they will, for twenty aeons, be born in the northern continent of Uttarakuru. For twenty-five aeons they will be born as equals among the gods of the Thirty-Three. After passing away from the Thirty-Three, they will again be born in Uttarakuru. They will not be born in a mother's womb. They will behold hundreds of thousands of world-systems, and every single one of them will be called Sukhāvatī. They will

behold all buddha-fields, and having beheld them, they will remain right there, and right there they will awaken to complete and perfect awakening.

Sarvaśūra, such is the great power of this teaching known as the Paired Dharma. Those who have faith in it will never die in a state of confusion, never departing without having relinquished bewilderment. They will also come to possess completely pure moral discipline.

Sarvaśūra, there are some who think: even though the Tathāgata, day and night, liberates very many sentient beings, the realm of sentient beings is still not exhausted — many make aspirations for awakening, many are born in the higher realms of the world, and many attain nirvāṇa, yet why is it that sentient beings are never exhausted? There are indeed sentient beings who wonder about this.

Now, other practitioners who are non-Buddhists (tīrthikas), wandering ascetics, and naked ascetics think to themselves: "We wish to have a debate with the śramaṇa Gautama." Then brahmins, other tīrthika practitioners, eighty-four thousand wandering ascetics, and many hundreds of naked ascetics all came to where the Blessed One was in Rājagṛha.

At that time and moment, the Blessed One smiled. Then the bodhisattva, the great being Maitreya rose from his seat, arranged his upper robe over one shoulder, placed his right knee on the ground, and with palms joined turned toward the Blessed One and addressed him thus:

"Blessed One, Tathāgatas, arhats, fully and perfectly awakened buddhas do not smile without cause and condition — what then is the cause, what is the condition for this smile?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, listen. Today a great assembly will gather here in Rājagṛha."

"Blessed One, who will come here — gods, nāgas, yakṣas, humans, or non-humans?"

The Blessed One declared: "Maitreya, today all of these — gods, nāgas, yakṣas, humans, and non-humans — will come here. Eighty-four thousand brahmins will also come here. Nine thousand million tīrthika practitioners, wandering ascetics, and naked ascetics will come, and I will engage them in debate. In order to pacify the contentiousness of all of them, the Dharma will be taught. All those brahmins will generate the mind set on unsurpassed, complete, and perfect awakening. All nine thousand million tīrthika

practitioners, wandering ascetics, and naked ascetics will attain the fruit of stream-entry."

Eighteen thousand million nāga kings will come, and they will hear the Dharma from me. Having heard it, every one of them will generate the mind set on unsurpassed, complete, and perfect awakening. Sixty thousand million sons of the gods of the Pure Abodes will come. Thirty thousand million evil māras together with their retinues will come. Twelve thousand million asura kings will come. Some five hundred kings together with their retinues will come to hear the Dharma, and all of them, having heard the Dharma from me, will generate the mind set on unsurpassed, complete, and perfect awakening.

Then the great bodhisattva Maitreya prostrated with his head at the feet of the Blessed One, circumambulated the Blessed One three times, and vanished from that very spot.

Next, the great bodhisattva Sarvashūra rose from his seat, arranged his outer robe over one shoulder, placed his right knee on the ground, and with palms joined turned toward the Blessed One and bowed. He then addressed the Blessed One in these words: "Blessed One, what are the names of those approximately five hundred kings?"

The Blessed One declared: "Sarvashūra, listen well. There is King Joyful, King Deeply Joyful, King Supreme Flock of Victors, King Host of Brahmā, King Voice of Brahmā, King Lovely to Behold, King Host of the Beloved, King Host of the Joyful, King Essence of Form, King Resplendent Victor, and King Noble Man — these and others, approximately five hundred kings in all, each attended by retinues of a hundred thousand million. All of them, with the sole exception of King Noble Man, have entered without remainder into the path to unsurpassed, complete, and perfect awakening.

From the east, thirty thousand million bodhisattvas will come. From the south, fifty thousand million bodhisattvas will come. From the west, sixty thousand million bodhisattvas will come. From the north, eighty thousand million bodhisattvas will come. From the direction below, ninety thousand million bodhisattvas will come. From the direction above, one hundred thousand million bodhisattvas will come — and every single one of them abides perfectly on the tenth ground. All of those bodhisattvas are traveling toward Rājagṛha, the great royal city, making their way to behold the Blessed One. Every one of those bodhisattvas has also entered without remainder into the path to unsurpassed, complete, and perfect awakening."

Then the Blessed One addressed the great bodhisattva Sarvashūra: "Sarvashūra, go to the world-systems of the ten directions and announce to all bodhisattvas: 'Today the Tathāgata is teaching the Dharma in the great royal city of Rājagṛha. All of you who dwell in the worlds of the ten directions, join your palms and bow — and as soon as you have heard this message and understood it, return without delay to hear the Dharma.'"

Then the great bodhisattva Sarvashūra rose from his seat, prostrated with his head at the feet of the Blessed One, circumambulated the Blessed One three times, and by the power of his miraculous abilities vanished from sight.

Then the great bodhisattva Sarvashūra traveled to the world-systems of the ten directions and announced to all the bodhisattvas: "Today the Tathāgata is teaching the Dharma in the great royal city of Rājagṛha. You should all say 'Excellent!' to this, for by doing so you will this very day obtain great benefit and great happiness." With that proclamation he traveled throughout the world-systems of the ten directions, paid homage to all the buddhas, and stirred the bodhisattvas to action with the following simile: just as a man endowed with great strength can travel a great distance with a single snap of his fingers, so the great bodhisattva Sarvashūra arrived at once at the great royal city of Rājagṛha, in the presence of the Blessed One, and took his seat before him.

There assembled in that place brahmins, other non-Buddhists (tīrthikas), wandering ascetics, and naked renouncers. There assembled also gods, nāgas, yakṣas, a great multitude of people, and a king with his retinue of about five hundred. There assembled too the evil māra with his retinue numbering thirty-three trillion.

At that moment the great royal city of Rājagṛha trembled and shook. Then from throughout the world-systems of the ten directions a rain of divine sandalwood powder fell, and a rain of divine flowers fell, and all of it came to rest in tiers, like a many-storied palace, above the crown of the Blessed One's head. At that time Śakra (Indra), lord of the gods, wielded his vajra (thunderbolt scepter) in the presence of the Tathāgata. Then four mighty wind-kings arose and stirred from the four directions, and they swept away the rubbish, the banners, and the dust from the great royal city of Rājagṛha, carrying all of it outside the city walls. Throughout the world-systems of the ten directions a rain of scented water then fell. Throughout the world-systems of the ten directions a rain of blue utpala flowers, lotuses, kumuda flowers, and

white lotuses also fell, and all those flowers came to rest above the crowns of those sentient beings' heads in the form of parasols of flowers. In the sky above the crown of the Tathāgata's head, eighty-four thousand many-storied palaces came to rest, and from within each of those eighty-four thousand palaces there arose eighty-four thousand thrones adorned with the seven precious substances, and upon each and every one of those thrones the Tathāgata was seated, teaching the Dharma. Then this great trichiliocosm shook and trembled in six ways.

Then the great bodhisattva Sarvashūra turned to face the Blessed One, joined his palms, and bowed, and addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, what is the cause and what is the condition for such miraculous displays as these appearing here in the great royal city of Rājagṛha?"

The Blessed One declared: "Consider this simile. There is a certain wild, arrogant person, beset by self-grasping and grasping at what is mine, who has fallen into poverty. The king anoints his head, and that person then goes to the gate of the king's palace and, arriving there, presses insistently, wishing to enter the inner palace. The king's ministers and retinue seize him and beat him in many ways. Now when the king hears that this poor man is pressing insistently, wishing to enter, the king thinks to himself: 'Without any doubt this person wants to kill me.' Enraged, the king says to his retinue: 'Today you will take that man out to the forest and put him to death.'"

'Kill his servants, his parents, his children, his male slaves, his female slaves, and all his workers.' With that command, all of them were put to death, and all the friends and companions of that man were pierced by the unbearable thorn of grief.

In just the same way, when a Tathāgata, an arhat, a perfectly and fully awakened buddha, teaches the Dharma, those among ordinary childish people who are arrogant in the very manner described take hold of the Tathāgata through form, color, marks, shape, and signs, thinking: 'That is the body of the Tathāgata.' Having heard many teachings, they fall into heightened pride, speak all manner of nonsense, and, overwhelmed by self-grasping and grasping at what is mine, they themselves will neither listen to nor explain such Dharma as this. If someone teaches them even a sūtra, a verse, or even so much as a single analogy, they do not hold it in attention or lend it their ear, saying: 'I already know this.' Why is that? Because they have become arrogant. They are heedless through much hearing.

Those who associate with such ordinary childish people will not come to practice such Dharma as this. They will not come to hear the words of such Dharma as this. Rather, they grow intoxicated by their much learning. People of this kind set down their own fabrications and establish their own textual positions. They deceive themselves and all the world alike, consume vast amounts of alms from villages and towns for no purpose, and even having eaten, they do not digest it well. At the time of their death, great fear will arise. The sentient beings around them will say to such a person: 'You have extensively instructed us in the crafts; how is it that you are unable to establish a self?' And he will say to them: 'Friends, I am at this moment unable to establish a self.' Then those sentient beings will break into lamentations of many kinds.

Just as in the other case, where through the conditions of his own karma that single person caused the killing of a great many kinsmen at another's hands, so too those sentient beings, at the time of their death, break into lamentations and, on account of their unwholesome companions, they see themselves falling toward rebirth in the hells or in the realm of animals.

In just the same way, brahmins and other non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) say to you: 'Do not grow intoxicated. Consider this example: just as a bird whose wings are not yet fully grown cannot fly into the sky to reach the world of the gods, so too you will not be able to attain nirvāṇa, for you do not possess supernatural powers of that kind.' Why is that? 'Because, born through the force of karma in the birth-place of a little bird, this body will not long endure before it falls apart and you die at the end. At the time of death they will be without savour and will think: why did we take up this body? We have experienced neither the pleasures of the world of the gods nor the pleasures of the human world, nor have we come to dwell in the state of nirvāṇa. If we have taken up this body to no purpose, what then will become of our destiny? Who will be our support? Where will we be born, and where will we perish?' And they will be utterly terrified.

Then the Blessed One (the Buddha) spoke to those non-Buddhist practitioners, wandering ascetics, and naked ascetics:

"Do not be disheartened here in this precious Jambudvīpa. Do not place yourselves outside the jewel of the Dharma. Friends, ask the Tathāgata whatever you wish, and I will bring all your intentions to complete fulfilment."

Then all those brahmins and other non-Buddhist practitioners, wandering ascetics, and naked ascetics rose from their seats, arranged their upper robes over one shoulder, pressed their palms together, and made this request to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, the Tathāgata, like a parasol, liberates sentient beings entirely from cyclic existence, yet among the classes of sentient beings there is no decrease or increase to be found. Blessed One, by what cause and by what condition do you demonstrate the arising and ceasing of those sentient beings?"

Then the Blessed One spoke to the bodhisattva great being Mañjuśrī's Retinue: "In order to dispel the great remorse of the non-Buddhist practitioners and to cause the great lamp of the Dharma to blaze, put on the great armour and ask the great question worthy of asking, so that in the time to come young and old sentient beings alike may come to know arising and ceasing."

Mañjuśrī's Retinue replied: "Blessed One, there are also old sentient beings who know nothing, just like the young."

"Mañjuśrī's Retinue, consider this example: one person washes his hair, puts on fresh new clothing, and steps outside his house. The other sentient beings say to him, 'You have put on your fine new clothing well.' But another person also washes his hair and puts on freshly washed old clothing, and because that old clothing is worn and faded, even though that person has washed his hair he does not appear handsome, nor does his clothing appear fine. In the same way, Mañjuśrī's Retinue, the old sentient beings there are in Jambudvīpa are not beautiful, whereas the young sentient beings demonstrate arising and ceasing."

Then all those brahmins and other non-Buddhist practitioners, wandering ascetics, rose from their seats and said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, among ourselves, who are the young and who are the old?"

The Blessed One declared: "You have repeatedly experienced sensations again and again in the hells, among the animals, and among the hungry ghosts, and yet you have still never had your fill of it. For that reason you are old."

Then all those brahmins and all the nāga kings said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, from this time forth we take no delight in experiencing sensations of suffering in cyclic existence."

And the other non-Buddhist practitioners, wandering ascetics, and naked ascetics said: "Even among the young sentient beings, there is not one who is

capable of directly perceiving the nature of reality."

When they had said this, the bodhisattva great being Mañjuśrī's Retinue said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, pray look upon why sentient beings are so difficult to guide."

The Blessed One declared: "Mañjuśrī's Retinue, listen. The Tathāgata perceives the entire world directly."

Then ninety-four billion young sentient beings sat in the presence of the Tathāgata and neither paid homage to the Tathāgata nor spoke a word.

Then the bodhisattva great being Mañjuśrī's Retinue said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, what is the cause and what is the condition by which these sentient beings do not speak to the Blessed One, do not speak to him at all, do not pay homage, and make no request of the Blessed One?"

The Blessed One declared: "Mañjuśrī's Retinue, listen. These young sentient beings are incapable of directly perceiving the nature of reality." As for those sentient beings who were saying this —

"You should regard these members of the Medicinal Cohort as young sentient beings." Those sentient beings then said this: "Venerable Blessed One, we are indeed young sentient beings. Venerable Sugata, we are indeed young sentient beings."

The Blessed One declared: "These sentient beings are ones who make the world directly manifest. Now show the measure of the world from within your own bodies."

At that very time and moment, nine hundred and forty million young sentient beings, without leaving their bodies, dwelt in the sky above and attained full establishment in the tenth ground (bhūmi).

Then the bodhisattva great being Medicinal Cohort said this to the Blessed One: "Those sentient beings who apply diligent effort for the sake of utterly exhausting and utterly purifying saṃsāra — such beings are well and truly found. Blessed One, these sentient beings are born right now. Blessed One, these sentient beings are completely liberated right now, and we see that all of them have fully attained the tenth ground."

The Third Section.

Then brahmins, and other tīrthika wanderers (non-Buddhist adherents), wandering ascetics, naked practitioners, nāga kings, and Māra the Evil One

together with his retinue — all of them arrived and, intending to cause mischief, said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, we have come here into the presence of the Tathāgata and, having heard this enumeration of Dharma, may we attain such happiness as that of a buddha. May there be in the world a Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and fully awakened buddha such as this."

The Blessed One declared: "Good ones, it is just so. Since you have come into the presence of the Tathāgata and have heard this enumeration of Dharma of the pair, you have aroused the mind of unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. Therefore all of you, before long, will fully and perfectly awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening."

The moment the Blessed One had spoken these words, all of those tīrthikas attained acceptance of the doctrine of non-arising, and having become bodhisattvas fully established on the tenth ground, all those bodhisattvas rose into the sky seven tāla-tree heights into the intermediate space above, and offered to the Tathāgata multi-storied mansions of seven kinds of precious substances. They all also consecrated various magical transformations and manifested displays of miraculous power.

Then, dwelling on the topmost crown of the Blessed One's head, various small flowers of many kinds were scattered upon the Blessed One, and all the Tathāgatas applied their minds to it, generating the perception of a buddha with respect to their own bodies.

Many hundreds of thousands of millions of sons of the gods also scattered offerings before the Tathāgata, saying these words: "The ascetic Gautama has found great acquisition. He has great fields. He is the protector of the world. He has found the arousal of the power of meditative absorption. He is one who is wise and who seeks wisdom. It is he who, through skillful means, gradually liberates such sentient beings as these fully from saṃsāra — and by just a single well-spoken word, that many sentient beings have been completely liberated from saṃsāra."

Then the bodhisattva great being Medicinal Cohort rose from his seat, arranged his upper robe over one shoulder, placed his right knee on the ground, joined his palms together in the direction of the Blessed One with a bow, and said this to the Blessed One:

"Blessed One, what cause and what condition is it by which these sons of good family utter such words, perform many miraculous displays, and produce many praises of the Tathāgata?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, listen. Those are not praises of me. Rather, they will praise their own bodies and place their own bodies upon the noble Dharma-throne. From their own bodies they will emit rays of Dharma-light. And in order to fully and completely awaken to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening, they will be embraced by all buddhas. Having fully and perfectly awakened, they will teach the Dharma."

Then the bodhisattva great being Medicinal Cohort said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, Sugata, although many sentient beings have been fully liberated under the canopy-sign, still sentient beings have not yet been exhausted."

The Blessed One declared: "Medicinal Cohort, it is good, it is good that you think to ask the Tathāgata about this matter. Medicinal Cohort, consider this: suppose there is a person who is wealthy, of great riches and great possessions, endowed with wealth, grain, storehouses, and many granaries, with many male servants, female servants, workers, and people who live by wages — a person who owns great heaps of treasure and many fields and pleasure gardens, and who possesses abundant grain such as barley, wheat, rice, beans, lentils, and the like. That person, having sown seeds of all those grains in the spring season, at another time sees all those seeds fully ripen. He then separates out each of those various grains, stores them away, and eats from them until the next spring season, sowing again as before. In the same way, Medicinal Cohort, when all the previously accumulated karma of sentient beings has been fully exhausted, they then seek a field of merit and cultivate roots of virtue. Having cultivated them, they diligently accomplish those virtuous qualities, cause all wholesome phenomena to increase, and give rise to joy and gladness. Medicinal Cohort, that mind of joy and gladness will not be wasted for ten million eons.

"Medicinal Cohort, in the same way, a bodhisattva who has first aroused the mind will never become one whose roots of virtue are wasted — in short, they will thoroughly understand all phenomena."

He asked: "Blessed One, what kinds of dreams does a bodhisattva who has first aroused the mind see?"

The Blessed One declared: "Medicinal Cohort, a bodhisattva who has first aroused the mind will see many frightening things in dreams. Why is that? It is in order to thoroughly purify all karma. A sentient being with evil karma cannot dispel unbearable suffering. Yet even seeing fearful dreams, that is not

something to be frightened of — those are evil dreams."

He asked: "Blessed One, in what way does a bodhisattva who has first aroused the mind see frightening things in dreams?"

The Blessed One declared: "Medicinal Cohort, first, one sees a blazing fire. The bodhisattva should then understand that all one's afflictions have been burned away. Medicinal Cohort, second, even if the bodhisattva who has first aroused the mind sees thunder and great peals of thunder, one should not be frightened. Why is that? Medicinal Cohort, it is because, in the same way, all that is bound by delusion has been turned back and negativities have been purified. Medicinal Cohort, third, in the dreams of the bodhisattva who has first aroused the mind, one sees great fearful things."

He asked: "Blessed One, what are they?"

The Blessed One declared: "Even if one sees one's own head being cut off, Medicinal Cohort, one should not be frightened by that. Why is that? It is because one's attachment, aversion, and delusion have been cut off, and one has become victorious over wandering through the six classes of beings. One is not dwelling among the beings in the hells, nor among the animals, nor among the hungry ghosts, nor among the asuras, nor among the nāgas, nor among the gods. Medicinal Cohort, a bodhisattva who has first aroused the awakening mind is taken to be reborn in the utterly pure buddha-fields.

Medicinal Cohort, in the future, at a later time, should some sentient being dedicate their mind fully to awakening, they should be regarded as bearing a great commitment. Even if they remain in a state of being looked down upon and despised, Medicinal Cohort, they should not give rise to a mind of discouragement, and they should not be intimidated.

Medicinal Cohort, I have taught the Dharma abundantly. Medicinal Cohort, throughout countless tens of millions of eons I have practiced austerities, yet, Medicinal Cohort, I did not practice those austerities for the sake of material enjoyments, nor for the sake of livelihood and provisions, nor for the sake of lordly comforts. Medicinal Cohort, I practiced those austerities for the sake of penetrating and internalizing the essential nature of the Dharma — yet, for as long as that lasted, I had not yet attained the unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening. Medicinal Cohort, at whatever time, on whatever occasion I heard this set of Dharma synonyms called the Pair, on that very day I became fully and perfectly awakened in unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening.

Medicinal Cohort, this set of Dharma synonyms is profound. This set of Dharma synonyms is difficult to encounter through hearing. Medicinal Cohort, the arising of Tathāgatas is likewise supremely difficult to encounter. Medicinal Cohort, those who hold this set of Dharma synonyms are likewise supremely difficult to encounter. All those who hear this set of Dharma synonyms will without exception become fully and perfectly awakened in unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening.

Medicinal Cohort, for a thousand eons they will churn through saṃsāra. They will readily encounter utterly pure buddha-fields. They will come to know cessation and the path. They will have the fortune of fully knowing the abiding place. They will have the fortune of fully knowing the virtuous abiding place. They will have the fortune of fully knowing higher knowledge and the virtuous abiding place. They will have the fortune of fully knowing the virtuous abiding place and cessation.

Medicinal Cohort, why is it called 'cessation'?"

He asked: "Blessed One, the abiding place of the Dharma is what I would call its meaning."

The Blessed One declared: "Medicinal Cohort, what is the abiding place of the Dharma?"

He asked: "Blessed One, what is called the Dharma is simply the application of diligence, the guarding of moral discipline, and being endowed with moral discipline — this I would call the treasury of the Dharma. Blessed One, this is where the treasury of the Dharma arises."

The Blessed One declared: "Medicinal Cohort, it is excellent, excellent to think of asking the Tathāgata about this matter."

He asked: "Blessed One, why do the Tathāgatas appear in the world?"

The Blessed One declared: "Medicinal Cohort, those who are endowed with extensive learning and who are wise come to fully know the arising of the Tathāgatas. Having come to know the arising of the Tathāgatas, they fully know this place of happiness that is the arising of the Tathāgatas. When the Tathāgatas arise in the world, sentient beings come to fully know all phenomena. Through skillful means, they come to fully know all phenomena."

They come to fully know worldly phenomena and transcendent phenomena. They come to fully know worldly wisdom and transcendent wisdom.

He asked: "Having realized wisdom itself, who would seek nirvāṇa?"

The Blessed One declared: "Medicinal Cohort, having fully known the Dharma, they fully know phenomena. Medicinal Cohort, having likewise fully known the gathering of the sacred Dharma, the first acquisition arises. Having grasped the Dharma just as it was heard, they come to acquire the quality of being endowed with Dharma.

"Medicinal Cohort, consider this example: A certain merchant, having set out carrying a thousand loads of gold without selling them, departed in order to make a profit. His parents said to him: 'Son, listen — carry a thousand tael of gold and bring the gold of others and your own back well.' The merchant took the gold and departed, and after about a month had passed, all that gold was secretly taken and made to disappear. In the aftermath, that man reflected, and feeling deep displeasure, the thorn of grief pierced his heart. Overcome with shame and embarrassment, he did not return to his own home. When his parents heard this, they were despondent. The thorn of grief piercing their hearts, they even tore their garments, crying: 'That wretched son was born into our household in the form of a child, has destroyed every part of the household, has left us without anything we need, has caused us suffering, and was put to work as a servant.' With such words of lamentation, his parents, in their despondency, came to the time of their death. Then, when the son heard that his parents, despondent on account of him, had come to the time of their death, he too became despondent and came to the time of death.

"In precisely the same way, Medicinal Cohort, when the Tathāgata explains this matter, those who have no faith in my teaching — they, in their hopeless despair, at the time of death will have the thorn of grief pierce their hearts as they come to the time of death. Just as those parents, becoming despondent, grieved over the gold, pierced by the thorn of grief in their hearts, and were afflicted with the thorn of grief over the gold of others and their own — so too, Medicinal Cohort, those who have no faith in my teaching will, later at the time of death, beat their chests and wail, and they will experience painful sensations. The merit they accumulated through deeds done previously will be wasted and destroyed, and afterward they will not create merit endowed with a good realm. Their hearts being afflicted by the thorn of grief, at that very time and in that very moment, they will be born in the hells, in the realms of animals, and in the realm of the Lord of Death. Seeing unbearable and fierce things, at the time of death this thought will arise in their minds: 'Who will become a refuge for me, so that I will not come to see the hells, the animals,

the hungry ghosts, and the realm of the Lord of Death, and will not come to experience that painful sensation?' Then their parents spoke these words:

'O child, how can
the great terror of sickness
not come to arise? What is to be done?
Though you are frightened by sickness and death,
child, death does not yet exist for you.
From the fear and dread of sickness,
you will come to be liberated.
My consciousness is ceasing,
my body is greatly afflicted,
all my limbs are in suffering,
I have come to see death.
My eyes no longer see,
my ears no longer hear,
my nose will no longer receive,
my body's complexion is not at ease.
Limbs and digits are in suffering,
like wood, with no awareness left.
My death is not coming yet, you said —
Mother has exhausted all my consolation and cheer.'

The mother spoke: 'Child, it is not right for you to speak so.
Do not frighten me in the highest degree.
Because sickness has struck your body,
various appearances will be seen.'

The son spoke: 'Not even sickness do I see in the body;
there is no illness, there is no suffering.
I see that death is utterly unbearable —
my body has come to be devastated.'"

"When I see my entire body crushed and tormented by suffering, to whom shall I go for refuge? Who will there be to protect me?" The parents spoke: "Child, you should earnestly propitiate the gods. If you make offerings to the gods, you will live by their grace." The son spoke: "Whoever it is that will make me live — please do that. Go quickly, make haste, and ask the priest of the gods."

Then the parents went to the shrine of the god and presented incense to the god. Then the priest of the gods offered the incense to the god and spoke these words: "Propitiate the god with devotion. Make a sacrifice. Slaughter livestock for the god. Slaughter a person too. Then your son will be fully freed from his illness."

Then those parents thought: "We are poor — what shall we do? If the god is not pleased, our son will come to the time of his death. And if we are to please the god, we are too poor — from where shall we obtain a person and livestock?" Thinking this, they quickly went home, and set out to sell whatever household goods they had in order to buy livestock. Then they went to another person's house and said: "Good sir, if you lend us some gold and we are able to repay it within ten days, that is well. But if we cannot repay it, then from this very day we will bind ourselves as your servants and work." Having said this, the two of them took the gold and went to purchase a person. But the person they bought did not know that he was being bought to be killed.

Then those two deluded parents, without returning home, went to the shrine of the god and said to the priest of the gods: "Now quickly perform the sacrifice." Then the two parents themselves slaughtered the livestock and also slaughtered that person. Then the priest of the gods lit a fire intending to perform the sacrifice. And then the god descended and said: "I am taking your son away."

Then those two parents, filled with joy and gladness, said: "If our son recovers, it is worth it even if we become servants." Having made the sacrifice to the god, they returned home — and saw that their son had come to the time of his death. Then those two parents, wracked with suffering and deep despair, the thorn of grief piercing their hearts, their spirits broken, died right there in the same way.

Sāṃghika — one should not associate with bad companions. A question was put: "Blessed One, where were those sentient beings reborn?" The Blessed One declared: "Sāṃghika, do not ask me about the wretched physician. A question was put: "Blessed One, we ask. Sugata, we ask." The Blessed One declared: "Sāṃghika, listen. The mother was reborn in the great hell called Roaring Cries. The father was reborn in the great hell called Crushing. The son was reborn in the great hell of Heat. The priest of the gods was reborn in the great hell of Unrelenting Torment." A question was put: "Blessed One, where was the blameless person reborn? What became of him thereafter?" The

Blessed One declared: "Sāṃghika, in this case, the one who was displeased was reborn among the gods of the Thirty-Three." A question was put: "Blessed One, through what cause and through what condition was that person reborn equal in fortune to the gods of the Thirty-Three?" The Blessed One declared: "Sāṃghika, listen. At the time of that person's death, with a mind of faith toward the Tathāgata, he said once: 'I bow to the Buddha.' Sāṃghika, through that root of virtue he will experience the happiness of the gods of the Thirty-Three for sixty aeons. For eighty aeons he will recall his past lives birth after birth. And birth after birth he will be free from every thorn of grief."

From the moment of each birth it dispels all suffering. Yet to lead all those sentient beings entirely to nirvāṇa — that lies beyond one's power.

A question was put: "Blessed One, what has obstructed the complete deliverance of all sentient beings to nirvāṇa?"

The Blessed One declared: "The host of medicine must apply diligence."

A question was put: "Blessed One, what is this diligence that must be applied?"

The Blessed One declared: "Host of medicine, listen. 'Diligence' is that which points toward the fruits. That is to say: the fruit called stream-entry is a domain of diligence. The fruit called once-returning is a domain of diligence. The fruit called non-returning is a domain of diligence. The state of arhatship and the fruit of the arhat, called cessation — these are domains of diligence. The fruit of the pratyekabuddha and the understanding that is the fruit of the pratyekabuddha — these are domains of diligence. The fruit of the bodhisattva and the ground of awakening — these too are domains of diligence. Host of medicine, all of these are called the domains of diligence."

A question was put: "Blessed One, how shall we teach stream-entry and the fruit of stream-entry?"

The Blessed One declared: "Consider this analogy. Suppose a certain person plants a tree. On that very day the tree's roots take hold, and on that very day those roots descend to a depth of a yojana beneath the earth. Another person likewise plants a tree, but on that very day the wind stirs it and the tree's roots fail to take hold. The first person then removes the tree from that place, and the other person erupts into quarrel and dispute, crying, 'Why has my ground been dug up?' At that time the king heard that these two people had fallen into quarrel and dispute. The king sent a messenger, saying: 'Go, bring those two people here. His Majesty commands it.' The messenger ran in the form of a

swift man and said to those two: 'The king summons you.' At that, one of the two was afraid and frightened. The other, without fear or fright, was led to where the king was. They were brought before the king and stood in the royal presence. The king then spoke to these two men: 'Hey, you two — what are you quarreling and disputing about?' The two men rose and said to the king: 'Great King, hear us. We have not even a small plot of land of our own. On a piece of borrowed ground we planted a tree, but the wind stirred it and the roots did not take hold, and no leaves, blossoms, or fruit appeared. Great King, now this man accuses me of wrongdoing and has brought a lawsuit against me, but I have done no wrong. May you, O King, know that I have not the slightest fault in this matter.'

The king then summoned thirty million ministers, assembled them, and commanded them thus: 'You speak to it.' The ministers replied: 'What shall we say?' 'Has either of you ever seen or heard of a tree planted on the very day its roots took hold and on that same day produced leaves, blossoms, and fruit? Settle this matter between you within seven days or half a month.' The ministers then rose from their seats and said to the king:

'Great King, it is not proper for us to settle this matter. We have no standing to adjudicate it. Great King, this is astonishing. For now, let us put the question directly to this man himself: O man, tell us — is what you have said true?' The man replied: 'Great King, it is indeed true.' The king then spoke in verse:

On the very day the tree was planted,
on that same day its roots took hold,
and leaves and blossoms and fruit appeared —
to speak of this as happening on one day
is a claim most difficult to accept.
Nothing like this has ever been seen or heard.

Then that man joined his palms together and spoke these words to the king:

Please go yourself to see the tree you planted,
and look upon the roots that have taken hold.

Then the king went outside together with his thirty million ministers, and had both men placed under guard in prison. Then the king himself went to plant a tree, but that tree put forth no roots, and neither leaves nor blossoms nor fruit appeared. The king then fell into a rage and declared: 'Quickly, go now and fetch the axes for cutting down that tree.' The axes were brought. Then that man, enraged at the tree he had planted, cut away its leaves, blossoms, and

fruit. When that single tree was cut down, twelve trees appeared in its place. When those twelve trees were cut down, twenty-four trees appeared, complete with roots made of the seven precious substances, with leaves, and with shoots. Then from those twenty-four trees there appeared twenty-four birds with golden crests, golden beaks, and wings of the seven precious substances. Then the king, overwhelmed by the force of his own rage, took up the axe with his own hand and struck the tree. From the place where he struck it, water of immortality flowed forth. The king then departed in a troubled state of mind and gave the command: 'Release those two men from prison.' At that very instant a god came running and said: 'As you command.' The two men were released from prison and led to the place of the tree. The king then said: 'That tree, cut down as one, multiplied and became twenty-four — was it you who caused this? The tree I planted produced no roots, no leaves, no blossoms, and no fruit.'

Then the man replied: 'Great King, merit such as I possess is not yours to command.'

Then the thirty million ministers knelt on both knees upon the ground and spoke these words to the man: 'This king is unworthy. You yourself should be king.' Then that man spoke these verses to the ministers:

I have no desire for royal enjoyment.
I have no need of wealth or grain.
By my faith in the buddhas,
may I attain the highest of the two-footed.
In the peaceful expanse of nirvāṇa,
where the Tathāgatas go —
the Dharma that leads to the home of nirvāṇa,
this I shall teach to you.
Seated in cross-legged posture,
I then made a solemn vow:
through the karma I have previously created,
I have come to be in the king's prison.
By the aspiration I have now set forth,
may my karma be exhausted.

Then twenty-four million birds rang out their melodious chimes with their vajra beaks. And at that very time and moment, thirty-two thousand multi-storied palaces arose, each one measuring twenty-five leagues in every dimension.

From each of those multi-storied palaces there came twenty-five million birds with golden crests, golden beaks, and golden faces, and they spoke in the human tongue:

O King, you have not acted well.
Because you cut down that tree,
from among a hundred million trees —
come to dwell in the twenty-four.
Whatever sentient being planted this tree,
one who does not know what it is like —
through sinful actions, from now onward,
shall experience unpleasant fruit.

The king spoke:
I do not understand this matter.
O great ascetic, prophesy for me!

The birds spoke:
This one is the light of the world,
the one who shall become a perfect guide,
who shall liberate all sentient beings
from the prison of saṃsāra's existence.

The king spoke:
The second person through whom the tree did not grow —
who is that one?
What sinful action did he perform?
Let those born of two speak.

The birds spoke:
The one through whom the tree did not grow
is the fool Devadatta.
If one has done not even a little virtue,
how could his tree ever grow?

Then at that very time and moment, thirty million ministers, having heard this enumeration of the Dharma, all came to dwell fully on the ten grounds and each individually attained superknowledges. And that king too, dwelling on the ten grounds, subsequently attained manifest realization of virtuous qualities.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Bhaiṣajyasena, addressed the Blessed One with these words: Blessed One, by what cause and by what condition did

those thirty-three million ministers come to dwell on the ten grounds and individually attain superknowledges?

The Blessed One declared: Bhaiṣajyasena, listen, and I shall prophesy concerning this.

Then at that moment the Blessed One smiled. And at that moment, from the aperture of the Blessed One's mouth, rays of light of many colors, of various hues, of hundreds and thousands of colors — blue, yellow, red, white, the color of crystal, the color of silver — eighty-four thousand in number, issued forth, and with them illuminated world-realms without limit or bound. Then they returned, circled the Blessed One three times, and dissolved into the crown of the Blessed One's head.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Bhaiṣajyasena, rose from his seat, arranged his upper robe over one shoulder, placed his right knee on the ground, turned toward the Blessed One, pressed his palms together, and addressed the Blessed One with these words: Blessed One, Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas do not smile without cause or condition. What is the cause and what is the condition of this smile?

The Blessed One declared: Bhaiṣajyasena, do you see the multitudes of people coming toward me from world-realms in all four directions?

He replied: Blessed One, I do not see them.

The Blessed One declared: Bhaiṣajyasena, therefore look with discernment upon the multitude of people.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Bhaiṣajyasena, looked out, and from the eastern direction there appeared a tree seven thousand leagues tall, and gathered on one side of it was a multitude of twenty-five billion people, who were not speaking, not saying anything, not uttering a word, not eating, not rising, not walking — they stood there in complete silence. And from the southern direction there appeared a tree seven thousand leagues tall, and gathered at it was a multitude of twenty-five billion people, and they too were not saying anything, not speaking, entirely silent, utterly wordless, not rising, not walking — they stood there in complete silence. And from the western direction there appeared a tree seven thousand leagues tall, and gathered at it was a multitude of twenty-five billion people, and they too were not saying anything, not speaking, entirely silent, utterly wordless, not rising, not walking — they stood there in complete silence.

And from the northern direction there appeared a tree seven thousand leagues tall, and gathered at it was a multitude of twenty-five billion people, and they too were not saying anything, not speaking, entirely silent, utterly wordless, not rising, not walking — they stood there in complete silence. And from the lower direction there appeared a tree seven thousand leagues tall, and gathered at it was a multitude of twenty-five billion people, and they too were not saying anything, not speaking, entirely silent, utterly wordless, not rising, not walking — they stood there in complete silence. And from the upper direction there appeared a tree seven thousand leagues tall, and gathered at it was a multitude of twenty-five billion people, and they too were not saying anything, not speaking, entirely silent, utterly wordless, not rising, not walking — they stood there in complete silence.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Sde of Medicinal Herbs addressed the Blessed One with these words: "If, having asked, I may ask so as to receive a prophecy, and if the Blessed One would grant me that opportunity, I would put certain questions to the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and fully awakened buddha."

When this was said, the Blessed One spoke to the bodhisattva, the great being Sde of Medicinal Herbs in these words: "Sde of Medicinal Herbs, ask whatever you wish to ask, and by giving you a prophecy in response to each question I shall gladden your heart."

When this was spoken, the bodhisattva, the great being Sde of Medicinal Herbs addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, what is the cause, what is the condition, by which so great a multitude of people has arrived and remains here — having come from the worlds of the four directions, and now, counting also the people of the lower and upper directions, a multitude of fifty billion have arrived and are present?"

The Blessed One declared: "Sde of Medicinal Herbs, go and ask this question yourself directly to those Tathāgatas from whose world-realms these beings have come."

Sde of Medicinal Herbs asked: "By whose miraculous power shall I travel?"

The Blessed One declared: "Sde of Medicinal Herbs, go by the power of your own miraculous ability."

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Sde of Medicinal Herbs circumambulated the Blessed One three times, vanished from that very spot,

passed through ninety-six billion world-realms, and arrived in the world-realm called Moonlight, where the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and fully awakened buddha called Possessor of the Moon was teaching the Dharma, looking forward, surrounded by eighty billion bodhisattvas. There the bodhisattva, the great being Sde of Medicinal Herbs took his seat before the Blessed One Possessor of the Moon, and bowing with palms joined toward the Blessed One, addressed him with these words: "Blessed One, I see that when the multitudes gathered from the ten directions are assembled in the presence of the Tathāgata Śākyamuni in the world-realm of Endurance, they are visible there — yet when they are here, they are not visible. What is the reason for this, Blessed One?"

The Blessed One declared: "Sde of Medicinal Herbs, they are simply moving and dwelling right there."

Sde of Medicinal Herbs asked: "Blessed One, how so?"

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Sde of Medicinal Herbs went to where the Tathāgata Possessor of the Moon was, arrived there, took his seat in the Blessed One's presence, and addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, I have come having passed through ninety-six billion world-realms, and in all of them, however many sentient beings I saw — that many I see nowhere at all here."

The Blessed One declared: "Those sentient beings arose from trees without thought."

Sde of Medicinal Herbs asked: "Blessed One, who has seen and who has heard of beings arising from trees without thought?"

The Blessed One declared: "Sde of Medicinal Herbs, have you not seen and heard of beings that do not arise from trees without thought?"

"Blessed One, I have not seen nor heard of such."

The Blessed One declared: "Sde of Medicinal Herbs, if you wish to see them, I shall show you now."

"Blessed One, I wish it. O Sugata, I wish it."

Then from the field of the Tathāgata Possessor of the Moon, with the extending of a hand, there arose from that hand a hundred billion assemblies of people, and each assembly of people extended their hundred hands and scattered incense, garlands, and various unguents toward the Tathāgata.

The Blessed One declared: "Sde of Medicinal Herbs, do you see this assembly of people scattering incense, garlands, and unguents toward the Tathāgata?"

"Blessed One, I see it. O Sugata, I see it."

The Blessed One declared: "These assemblies of people who have arisen are without thought. These people are without thought."

Then all of those hundred billion people — each of whom had a hundred hands — had all their hands fall away at once.

The bodhisattva, the great being Sde of Medicinal Herbs, seeing this, addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, what is this? O Sugata, what is this? The hundred hands of these people fell away in an instant. Blessed One, if even one who has a hundred hands cannot be freed, what need is there to speak of a person with only two hands?"

The Blessed One declared: "Sde of Medicinal Herbs, in just the same way, sentient beings are born without thought and they cease without thought. Sde of Medicinal Herbs, know that even that body has come to be without thought."

Sde of Medicinal Herbs asked: "Blessed One, among those sentient beings, which are the young and which are the old?"

The Blessed One declared: "Sde of Medicinal Herbs, there are young sentient beings and there are old ones."

"Blessed One, which are the young and which are the old?"

The Blessed One declared: "Those who just now fell down — those are the old. Those who were born from the trees — those are the young."

"Blessed One, I wish to see the young sentient beings."

Then the Tathāgata Possessor of the Moon extended the palm of his right hand, and from the ten directions a hundred billion assemblies of people in each direction came forth. From the directions above and below, fifty billion assemblies of people in each came. When those assemblies of people arrived, they bowed their heads to the feet of the Blessed One in homage; yet they said nothing to the Tathāgata, spoke no word at all, uttered nothing whatsoever, and stood in silence.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Sde of Medicinal Herbs, addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, for what reason do those sentient beings say nothing to the Tathāgata, speak no word at all, and utter

nothing whatsoever?"

The Blessed One declared: "Sde of Medicinal Herbs, do you not know? The ground has no thought and does not speak; it utters no word at all and does not know even an aggregate of Dharma. Why is that? Sde of Medicinal Herbs, here, although some of the young sentient beings are seen, they do not know birth, or cessation, or aging, or illness, or sorrow, or lamentation, or separation from what is beloved,

or meeting with the unpleasant, or friendship, or separation, or death, or untimely death, or unbearable suffering — they know none of these things at all. Even seeing them, they do not become disenchanted; how much less could they come to know them? Sde of Medicinal Herbs, these things must be trained in again and again.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Sde of Medicinal Herbs, addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, from where do those young sentient beings who do not seek the Dharma come? From where do they pass away, and where are they reborn?"

The Blessed One declared: "Sde of Medicinal Herbs, listen well. Those who take hold of a human body — they are not made by a silversmith, nor made by a coppersmith, nor made by a carpenter, nor made by a potter, nor are they made through royal fear. Rather, they arise from the coming together of a man and a woman endowed with sinful actions. Those sentient beings, learning the various crafts again and again, thereby experience unbounded, unbearable suffering and unbearable feelings. In that, they experience the karmic maturation of the previously committed sinful and non-virtuous actions. Sde of Medicinal Herbs, these young sentient beings who appear here without standing upright will experience just such feelings of suffering. Sde of Medicinal Herbs, that is why they say nothing and say nothing at all. Sde of Medicinal Herbs, in this way those young sentient beings do not know virtue, they do not know birth, they do not know cessation, and they will not attain a human body — these, Sde of Medicinal Herbs, are called young sentient beings."

He asked: "Blessed One, how are young sentient beings born, and how do they cease?"

The Blessed One declared: "Sde of Medicinal Herbs, it is like this. Just as when someone touches fire with wood, and that wood then gradually bursts into flame — in just the same way, Sde of Medicinal Herbs, at the very beginning

one is born in a human body. Having been born, one experiences feeling right away."

He asked: "Blessed One, who is born here, and who, having been born, passes fully into nirvāṇa?"

The Blessed One declared: "Sde of Medicinal Herbs, a buddha is born, and a Tathāgata passes fully into nirvāṇa. It is like this, for example: a king had someone bound and put in prison within a pitch-dark dwelling, and that person, having entered that pitch-dark dwelling, perceived the pitch-dark dwelling as nothing but pitch darkness. Then another person, touched by a previous feeling of suffering, saw him, and that person was filled with distress. Thinking, 'One who has not previously experienced suffering will have his life and livelihood cut off,' that person brought fire there and threw a small fire into the dwelling. The person who had been imprisoned saw that fire. Seeing it, he breathed in relief and felt joy arise. That fire then burned with whatever fuel fed its burning and set the entire dwelling ablaze, and that very person was consumed there. When the king heard that he had been burned, he was displeased and thought to himself: 'From now on I will not have any sentient being imprisoned in my realm.' The king then said to the sentient beings dwelling in his realm: 'O sentient beings, do not be afraid, do not be frightened, do not be in fear. From now on, no one in my realm shall be executed by punishment or put in prison. No sentient being shall be deprived of life. O sentient beings, do not be afraid.' In just this way of breathing relief, Sde of Medicinal Herbs, the Tathāgata has burned all afflictions and fully pacified all illness. Just as, when the dwelling burned, the very body of the person was also burned —

just as one who has entered upon the welfare, benefit, and happiness of sentient beings fully liberates those sentient beings who are bound from their bondage — in just that same way, the Tathāgata, having abandoned the stains of attachment, aversion, and delusion, has arisen in the world like a lamp for all sentient beings, and has fully liberated sentient beings from the bodies of hell-beings, animals, hungry ghosts, and asuras, liberating both the young among sentient beings and the old.

Then from the sky above, these verses arose:

The field of the Victor is wondrous,
a good field, well and truly cultivated.
Whatever seeds are planted there

will never be wasted or lost.

The field of the Victor is a pure field,
the teaching of the Buddha is praised.
In order to embrace all sentient beings
the Teacher has also employed skillful means.

Though dwelling in the expanse of nirvāṇa,
he shines forth everywhere upon the earth.
Ever pacifying the world,
he purifies the fields where buddhas bestow their gifts.

He liberates the young among sentient beings,
he liberates the old as well.
He liberates all sentient beings
from the three realms, one by one.

He has closed the doors of hell,
he has liberated animals and hungry ghosts.
Having pacified this world,
he brings happiness to the world beyond.

Then the Blessed One smiled and declared:

It is good to see the virtuous,
and good indeed to see the buddhas.
Good is the field of the sacred Dharma's qualities,
and good to see the Saṅgha assembled.
Good also is the paired teaching,
and good is the complete destruction of wrongdoing.

Then the great bodhisattva Sde of Medicinal Herbs bowed with palms joined
toward the Blessed One and addressed him thus: "Blessed One, what was the
cause and condition for the Blessed One's smile?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, did you see these young
sentient beings?"

He replied: "Blessed One, I saw them. Sugata, I saw them."

The Blessed One declared: "All of these companies of Medicinal Herbs will,
from this very day, be established on the ten grounds."

Then the great bodhisattva Sde of Medicinal Herbs, dwelling in the sky above at a height of eighty thousand leagues, and eighty billion gods, rained down a shower of flowers upon the Blessed One. Those young sentient beings too joined their palms and paid homage.

Then the great bodhisattva Sde of Medicinal Herbs, remaining in the sky, spoke these words. With them the great trichiliocosm world-system was filled with sound. The sentient beings born in the thirty-two great hells heard that sound. The thirty-two classes of gods heard that sound. The great trichiliocosm world-system shook in six ways. The eighty-four thousand nāgas within the great ocean were stirred. Thirty billion rākṣasas came to this continent of Jambudvīpa. Twenty-five billion hungry ghosts, yakṣas, and rākṣasas came from the palace of Lāṅkā and gathered in a great assembly before the Blessed One.

Then, as the Blessed One taught the Dharma to those young sentient beings, one hundred billion great bodhisattvas came from world-systems in the ten directions, each by their own miraculous power.

This was the fourth and final section.

Then the great bodhisattva Sde of Medicinal Herbs bowed with palms joined toward the Blessed One and —

spoke these words to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, a great multitude of bodhisattvas has gathered and come. A great multitude of Sugatas has come. Blessed One, a great multitude of gods and nāgas has gathered and come. And many tens of billions of rākṣasas have come from the palace of Lāṅkā and assembled here."

Then the Blessed One said to the great bodhisattva Sde of Medicinal Herbs: "Son of good family, come forward." Thereupon the great bodhisattva Sde of Medicinal Herbs descended from above by the power of his miraculous ability, bowed with palms joined toward the Blessed One, and spoke these words to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, there is what is called an aggregate of Dharma, an aggregate of Dharma. Blessed One, by what measure is something called an aggregate of Dharma?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, what is called an aggregate of Dharma is this: one who thoroughly seeks the holy life and, having thoroughly sought the holy life, abandons all wrongdoing. Son of good family, do you see that those young sentient beings who abandon unchaste conduct will without

fail attain dhāraṇīs and come to be endowed with all Dharmas?"

He said: "Blessed One, by what means do so many sentient beings gather and listen to an aggregate of Dharma?"

Then the Blessed One declared to the great bodhisattva Sde of Medicinal Herbs: "Sde of Medicinal Herbs, there are many sentient beings who do not listen to birth itself as suffering, who do not listen to aging itself as suffering, who do not listen to illness as suffering, to grief as suffering, to lamentation as suffering, to separation from the beloved as suffering, to encounter with the unbeloved as suffering. As for death — it is the taking away of body and life on account of all suffering. Sde of Medicinal Herbs, this is called 'all suffering.'"

Then, having heard this teaching, those young sentient beings bowed with palms joined toward the Blessed One and spoke these words to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, we too will perish."

The Blessed One declared: "You and all sentient beings will die."

They asked: "Blessed One, how does one come to be overtaken by the hour of death?"

The Blessed One declared: "Sons of good family, at the hour of death there is a wind called 'that which arrests the final consciousness,' and a wind called 'that which confuses consciousness,' and a wind called 'that which agitates consciousness.' Sons of good family, at the hour of death these three winds cause the final consciousness to be overwhelmed, to be confused, and to be agitated."

They asked: "Blessed One, at the hour of death, when consciousness ceases, what are the three winds that destroy the body?"

The Blessed One declared: "Friends, it is what is called the blade, the goad, and the crushing pressure that destroy the body."

They asked: "Blessed One, what exactly is this 'body'?"

The Blessed One declared: "Friends, it may be called 'that which burns all through,' or 'that which is scorched,' or 'putrid filth,' or 'that which blazes,' or 'that of the charnel ground,' or 'a base and wretched mind,' or 'a heavy burden,' or 'that which is tormented by birth,' or 'that which is utterly churned by birth,' or 'that which scorches the vital force,' or 'that which causes separation from the beloved at death.' Friends, all of these are the body."

They asked: "Blessed One, how does one perish?"

They asked: "Blessed One, how does one live?"

The Blessed One declared: "Friends, what is called 'consciousness' is death. What is called 'one endowed with life' — that, friends, is living.

Friends, what is called 'the body' is death. It is wound about by tens of millions of sinews. It is possessed of eighty-four thousand pores. It is bound together by twenty thousand limbs. It is held firm by three hundred and sixty bones. Within the body dwell eighty-four kinds of worms, and all those living creatures too are subject to death, and subject also to the cessation of death. When a person dies, all those creatures are cut off from hope. At that moment all the creatures devour one another, and the winds surge and stir, and then those creatures experience feelings of suffering. Some grieve on account of a son. Some grieve on account of a daughter. Some grieve on account of a relative. All of them are pierced by the thorn of grief. They begin to devour one another, and having devoured one another, when two creatures remain, those two fight for seven days, and when seven days have passed, one of the creatures is destroyed and one escapes.

Now, what is called the Dharma of one endowed with life? He thinks to himself: just as living creatures, by turning against one another, come to die, so too do the sentient beings who are childish ordinary persons turn against one another. They have no fear of birth. They have no fear of aging. They have no fear of illness. They have no fear of death. Just as two creatures fight, so too do childish ordinary persons fight with one another.

Then, at the time of death, virtuous persons spoke to him: 'Man, what is it you relied upon? Did you not see even a little of the faults? Did you not see the faults of birth? Did you not see the faults of aging and illness? Did you not see the faults of death?'

He replied: 'Friends, I did indeed see the faults of birth. I did see the faults of aging and illness. And at the very end of all, I did see the faults of death.'

They said: 'Then why did you not perform the deeds of wholesome roots? Why did you not perform the wholesome roots of the heap of Dharma that brings happiness to increase in both worlds? Friends, we put the question to you a second time: why did you not gather the accumulation of virtue that fully liberates from birth and death? Why did you not practice proper attention and individual examination? Did you not hear the sound of the striking of the wooden gong upon the earth? Did you not see seeds of virtue sown and spread across the field of the Tathāgata, or incense offered, or garlands, or lamps

given as gifts? Did you not see food and provisions offered to the Tathāgata, and the four assemblies satisfied? The four assemblies are monks, nuns, laymen, and laywomen who are devoted and faithful to the teaching. Thus, words were spoken for his benefit, and yet not even the slightest act of virtue was performed. You, O man, came to Jambudvīpa and committed non-virtue.'

At that time the Dharma King spoke verses as instruction to the dying man:

You encountered a Tathāgata appearing in the world,
you heard the sound of the wooden gong being struck,
yet though the Dharma was taught that leads to the peace of nirvāṇa,
you did not act upon it.

Then that man replied in verse:

I fell under the sway of a childish mind,
came under the power of evil companions,
and with a mind confused by desires
I committed evil deeds.

Pursuing desires,

I also slew living creatures.

By stealing from the Saṅgha,
unbearable fruit will come.

With a mind intent on harm,

I destroyed stūpas.

I also spoke harsh words abundantly.

I also caused my mother to grieve.

Whatever I did with this body —

I am now fully aware of those wrongs.

In the great hell of weeping and wailing

I see a birth of unbearable torment arising.

I will experience the sensation of being crushed and broken,

and likewise the sensation of intense heat,

and the unbearable torment of the Hell of No Respite —

all these sensations I shall experience in turn.

In the hell realm where beings are split wide open like lotuses,

cast into the darkness of black lines — a thing of great terror —

I shall be reborn again and again, a hundred times over.

Having slaughtered the beings of the hell realms,

I see even afterward that same terror:

I shall fall again and again into great terror
across a hundred leagues.
For them there is no finding an exit —
afterward they plunge further still into darkness.
In the hell called the Razor,
a thousand razors will arise,
and with a hundred million billion blades,
razors will appear before me.
Because I committed evil deeds,
they will hack this very body with those blades.
By a violent and unbearable great wind
that entire body will be shattered.
In just such a hell as this, constantly,
I will experience suffering.
This body is seen by all beings
to be thoroughly afflicted with pain.

To maintain my household and for the sake of others' goods,
I also took the wealth of others for myself.
My sons, my daughters,
my brothers and sisters likewise,
my father and mother as well —
many dear friends and companions,
servants and workers,
and likewise oxen, livestock, and attendants —
I was deceived into vile purposes.
Vessels of gold and silver,
and likewise fine silken garments —
by having them brought into the house I was deceived,
and I made the house very splendid.
In the company of men and women and dalliance,
with vīṇā and lute and cymbals playing,
I, my mind untamed, took delight.
Though I bathed the body with perfumed water,
still there is no remedy for what was done.
O body, you are without mind —
yet I was deceived on your account.

Henceforth there is not even a single sentient being
who will come to protect me.
When the great violent wind torments
this body without mercy,
I ate tasty and delicious food,
and with the tongue likewise enjoyed all manner of flavors.
Many fine and beautiful garlands of various kinds
I bound upon my head.
The eye was deceived by forms —
there is no refuge for the eye.
The wrongs I committed upon seeing —
those sins are the cause issuing from the eye.
The cutting off of hands by the vajra —
that is the cause now coming to my ears.
On both arms I fastened bracelets,
on each finger I placed rings,
on the throat a pearl necklace,
and both feet too were fully adorned.
I had netting made for it,
and had gold placed upon it.
On the body all manner of jewels,
and gold bracelets likewise.
Exulting greatly in grand enjoyments,
the mind became thoroughly steadfast in them.
Exceedingly soft to my touch,
I clung to it with intense craving.
Upon various cushions and bedding
I had this body installed at the height of comfort.
I bathed it with fine perfumed water,
and anointed it thoroughly with fragrant unguents.
With divine substances — camphor and sandalwood —
I fumigated it abundantly with incenses.
Having prepared beautiful colors,
I smeared it lavishly with musk-laden preparations.
With sesame oil, grain oils, and fragrant substances,
and flowers of campaka and the like —
after anointing it, I dressed it in fine kāsika cloth

of white linen, most exquisite.
Dismounting from the back of an elephant,
I mounted visibly upon the back of a horse.
I thought to myself: "I am a king,"
and people ran before me.
Well-trained performers in singing and dance —
I knew them all thoroughly.
Without cause or fault,
I shot deer with arrows and slew them.
Not knowing the world to come,
I committed such sins as these.

Because I consumed the flesh of others,
unbearable suffering will come to me —
not knowing this, not knowing death was coming,
with a childish mind I nourished my own body.

Now, when death comes for me,
there is no one at all to be my refuge.
You who are my kin, all of you —
what is the use of gazing into my face?
Why do you tear your garments?
Why do you weep and cry out in lamentation?
Why do you pull and dishevel your hair?
Why do you draw blood?
Why do you scatter dust upon your heads
and beat your chests?

While I was alive, you did not help me abandon sin —
what good does this do now?
This body of mine will be eaten
by jackals, dogs, ravens,
and vultures alike.
You nourished this body to no purpose.

Accompanied by the serpent of death,
a person is born again and again.
Seek out the kind of medicine
that will free you from this terror.

If the medicine the physician gave me
is not what I truly need,
then right now, at the moment of death,
give me instead the medicine of Dharma
that liberates from the serpent of affliction.
Do not give me flesh.

Though you tend this body,
it will without fail fall to ruin.
Why take on a heap of sin
that will give rise to suffering?
However well you care for this body,
it will only go on doing harmful deeds.

Sons and daughters, why do you look at me with your eyes?
Protect me from this illness!
Why weep pointlessly?
Sons and daughters, do not grieve over me.
To provide for your sake,
I stole the wealth of others.
Now that the hour of death has arrived,
what is the use of despair?

I am terrified of birth and of the lower realms,
utterly tormented by death.
Feeling, perception, formations,
and contact — these are acutely felt.
Driven by craving, the childish wander on,
and they receive unbearable fruits.
Born into a base lineage,
there too they are bound in sorrow.
Knowing my own merit to be slight,
I cause other people grief.
Generosity and moral discipline are thoroughly lost,
and I have turned my back on the Dharma.

Not knowing future lives,
afflicted by the serpent of afflictions,
the childish, blinded by ignorance,
wander where there is no liberation.

Not knowing what liberation truly is,
they commit sins through confusion.
The afflictions make the childish wander;
the mind is perpetually disturbed.
This body, bound by manifold fetters,
blazes and burns all over with fire.
In that place where there is no happiness,
the body wanders, utterly confused.
They do not know the happiness
from which the deepest bliss arises.
A buddha-field bestows happiness;
the wheel of Dharma is the supreme medicine.
Moral discipline is the discipline of truth;
the Tathāgata's voice is Brahmā's own song.

Then the Blessed One spoke to the bodhisattva, the great being
Medicines-Division: "Medicines-Division, when sentient beings are at the hour
of death, though they cry out in lamentation thus, nothing whatsoever can
protect them except the ripening of the fruit of virtuous karma." Having
spoken these words, he also proclaimed these verses:

Having committed sinful deeds,
sentient beings fall into the hells.
They are clothed in burning garments,
they drink molten iron in their thirst.
Fiery arrows rain down upon their bodies,
burning with unbearable intensity.
In that great terrifying hell,
their bodies are utterly incinerated.
They know no happiness,
they do not know the Dharma;
the childish wander in what is not the Dharma,
and they find not even a trace of bliss.

Possessed of faith and moral discipline in full,
endowed with wisdom and great austerity,
relying on a spiritual friend of virtue —
one thus becomes a Tathāgata swiftly.

So that buddhas may arise in the world,
apply yourself to the supreme of diligences,
embrace all sentient beings entirely,
and teach the Dharma through virtuous deeds.

With a mind of loving-kindness, and likewise
enter into equipoise in the supreme holy life.
Let the assembly of medicines, having heard these words,
strive to accomplish the highest.

Seeing liberation, and the buddhas,
proclaiming their names and leading beings forth,
being father and mother to the world —
this is what is called the awakening mind (bodhicitta).

Whoever teaches this Dharma in the world
is supremely rare to find as a spiritual friend.
Those who listen to the teaching of the buddhas
will become unsurpassable buddhas, the Sugatas.

Those who come to feel reverence
toward the peaceful buddhas and their sons —
they too shall become protectors of the world
who liberate all sentient beings.

Then the great bodhisattva Medicinal Host addressed the Blessed One, saying:
"Blessed One, why do these earth-regions shake and tremble so violently?"
When he had spoken thus, the Blessed One declared to the great bodhisattva
Medicinal Host: "Medicinal Host, look and see what you observe." The great
bodhisattva Medicinal Host looked, and saw that the earth had split open in
the four directions. Through the fissures in the earth, two billion humans
emerged from below, and two billion from the lower direction, and two billion
five hundred million from the upper direction. Then those young beings looked
all around and addressed the Blessed One, saying: "Blessed One, who are
these that have been born here?" The Blessed One declared: "Look upon these
multitudes of people." They replied: "Blessed One, we see them." The Blessed
One declared: "These multitudes of people have been born here for your
benefit and happiness." They asked: "Will these beings also die?" The Blessed
One declared: "Yes, friends, it is so — all sentient beings will die."

Then those young beings who had been born first, right from the very
beginning, turned toward the Blessed One, joined their palms together in

homage, and addressed him, saying: "Blessed One, we have no delight in beholding birth and death any further." The Blessed One declared: "Then do you have delight in attaining the power of diligence?" They replied: "We would behold the Tathāgata face to face. We would listen to whatever agreeable Dharma is requested and is pleasing to hear. We would behold the assembled Saṅgha of the Tathāgata's hearers. We would behold bodhisattvas endowed with great miraculous power and great might. Blessed One, in things such as these we do take delight — but in birth and death we have no delight in beholding."

Then the great bodhisattva Medicinal Host, by the power of miraculous ability, rose from his seat together with those five hundred bodhisattvas, and all of them, by miraculous power, proceeded into the sky above, sat down cross-legged, and entered into meditative concentration. From the bodies of all of them there emerged lions, tigers, serpents, and elephants. They displayed great and magnificent miraculous transformations. And yet they remained seated, still and cross-legged, in their place. They ascended as high as twenty thousand leagues upward.

they cause ten billion suns and moons to fall down. Then those young sentient beings addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, what is the cause and what is the condition for the arising in this world of great rays of light and the display of great miraculous transformations?"

The Blessed One declared: "Sons of good family, look upon the arising of these suns and moons."

They replied: "We see it, Blessed One. We see it, O Sugata."

The Blessed One declared: "This is a bodhisattva shining forth with rays of light from his own body, displaying miraculous power and wondrous transformation, and then, having displayed them, teaching the Dharma to sentient beings for the benefit of the many, for the happiness of the many, out of compassion for the world, and for the good, benefit, and happiness of the great multitude of beings, of gods, and of humans. Here he demonstrates a human body with strength and diligence, showing forth a power of this very kind."

They asked: "Blessed One, we beg that you teach the Dharma so that rays of radiant light may arise."

When they had spoken thus, the Blessed One addressed the great bodhisattva Medicinal Host with these words: "Medicinal Host, did you see the great trichiliocosm shake in six ways?"

He replied: "I saw it, Blessed One. I saw it, O Sugata."

He thought to himself: "I shall ask the Tathāgata about this matter." And as he formed that thought, the Blessed One declared: "Medicinal Host, ask whatever you wish, and I will gladden your mind by prophesying about each and every thing you ask. I will teach it, analyze it, and set forth in full all the times of past, future, and present."

He said: "Blessed One, please teach so as to dispel doubt. Blessed One, I see the Tathāgata surrounded by eighty-four thousand son-of-god beings, surrounded by eighty-four billion bodhisattvas, surrounded by twelve billion kings of nāgas, surrounded by eighteen billion elemental spirits, and surrounded by twenty-five billion hungry ghosts and flesh-eating demons."

The Blessed One declared: "Medicinal Host, these sentient beings have gathered here in this retinue before me without interruption, for the sake of hearing the Dharma. Medicinal Host, this very day they shall exhaust cyclic existence. Wishing to benefit all sentient beings, this very day they shall fully attain the ten grounds. Having fully abided in the ten grounds, they shall come to attain the expanse of nirvāṇa.

To be freed from old age and death,
they shall act and thereby come to gain happiness.
Having defeated the snare of affliction,
they shall attain the teaching of the buddhas."

He asked: "Blessed One, why do these beings, arising from many different realms of sentient existence in their great variety, encircle and remain with the Blessed One?"

The Blessed One declared: "Medicinal Host, listen.
How could confused and unknowing sentient beings
find liberation?

Today many of these young sentient beings
shall attain their forms.

In order to attain the ten grounds
they shall come to fully know all phenomena.

They shall attain the ten grounds,

they shall perform the deeds of buddhas,
they shall turn the wheel of Dharma,
they shall pour down a great rain of Dharma.
Because such sentient beings are gathered here,
I rejoice in my teaching.

Gods, nāgas, hungry ghosts,
and asuras beyond all measure —
abiding fully in the ten grounds,

they shall proclaim the sound of Dharma,
they shall beat the drum of Dharma,
they shall blow the conch of Dharma.

These young sentient beings too
shall come to be endowed with the power of diligence.
Just as the Tathāgata has attained it,
so shall they today attain the Dharma.

Then some five thousand young sentient beings rose from their seats, joined
their palms toward the Blessed One, bowed, and addressed him thus:

Because we have not sought the further shore,
in saṃsāra we face death.

The body is a heavy burden, O Blessed One,
and the great terror is unbearable.

We have not found the path,
and the path itself is nowhere to be had.

O Protector, if you would guide us,
gather us, we pray.

We beseech the Hero —
may the Guide teach the Dharma.

We were born with but little wisdom,
and we have not found happiness.

Teach us the Dharma,
and free us from unbearable suffering.

In whatever birth and wherever we are born,
may we behold a buddha.

Then the great bodhisattva Medicinal Host went to where those young sentient
beings were and spoke these words:

All of you, eat and drink —
drink too of the wondrous taste.
Once you are free of fear,
then afterward hear the fearless Dharma.

They replied: "Venerable elder, who are you? We do not know you. We see that you are supremely beautiful, your form is peaceful and greatly renowned. You have escaped from the realms of hungry ghosts, the terrible dangers of the world, the hells, and the animals. Just as a being might be made beautiful, all your sins are pacified. We see that in your hand you hold a vessel adorned with the seven precious substances, that around your body are jeweled cords, and that you are adorned with a mass of splendor. You are so peaceful — when you speak, we cannot answer. We have no need of food and drink, nor of delicious beverages. From food comes excrement, and likewise from drink comes urine. From fluids comes blood, and from blood comes pus — so food and drink together are of no use to us. We have no need of silk or wool cloth, nor of fine garments. Golden earrings we do not need, nor pearl necklaces. We need no finger-rings either — all of these are characterized by impermanence. We shall not go to the lower destinies — we seek life. We seek the happiness of the gods and the gift of Dharma. We need spiritual friends (*kalyāṇamitras*), not a wheel-turning king. From the supremely excellent continent, the wheel-turning king departs at death, and his sons do not follow in his wake, nor do his wives and daughters. The seven precious substances do not follow him after death, the great multitude of people he has gathered do not go with him, those who ran before him do not accompany him — from that point on it is no longer so. In a single lifetime a king, through impermanence, becomes a wanderer. Having performed many evil deeds, such ones fall weeping into the hells. However great the magical power of the seven precious substances that surrounds him on all four sides — when the moment of weeping ripens, where has that magical power gone? In whatever place they are no longer present, the dead cannot exercise magical power. Elder, lead us to where the Tathāgata dwells. Just as one longs to see a father and a mother, so do we long above all to see him. We have no mother, no father, no brothers or sisters. The Lord of the world, the Tathāgata — he himself is our father and our mother. He himself is the sun and the moon, supremely showing the path to happiness. Because from this point forth we shall take no more birth —"

— he who liberates beings from cyclic existence,
he who is the boat that ferries across

the dreadful river of the afflictions' flood.
By him sentient beings are utterly saved,
and from that point forth they turn back no more.
He who supremely reveals the highest awakening,
by him too is the sacred Dharma taught.
We have no need of food,
we do not desire the fruits of kingship.
The terror of the hells for sentient beings —
we shall not go to the world of the gods.
Human life, by contrast, is a state of ease,
and there omniscience appears to shine.
Those who have acted wrongly through their own karma
wander about with their lives cut short.
They do not know death is coming,
yet they understand the pleasures of enjoyment and the power of kingdoms.
Deceived by arising and ceasing,
they have no understanding and no fear.
Those whose minds are bewildered by impermanence
do not know the subtle phenomena,
do not attend to subtle matters,
and do not know the expanse of peace.
Having no sorrow at death and the passage,
they are born again and again.
Long tormented by suffering's pain,
forever beaten with blows,
they also plunder what belongs to others,
and likewise bind and kill.
Driven on by former misdeeds,
they are bound by the fivefold bondage.
Even their threads of hope are cut.
They are pierced by the sharp thorn of grief.
When consciousness ceases,
they pitifully lament and moan.
"Who will be my protector?" —
and they offer all their gold, their silver, their crystal,
and every possession they have,
saying, "I will even become a servant."

As a servant I shall perform
every task that is assigned to me."
We have no need of royal dominion and its wealth,
nor of grain and treasure,
nor do we need our own bodies.
Those who commit misdeeds are not freed.
Thus, Elder, for us
there is no need of food.
Kings who have eaten the finest food
will die nonetheless.
The sons of gods who have drunk
the most excellent drink will die nonetheless.
With flavors layered richly upon one another,
food and drink of every kind are arrayed
and brought before the king,
and the tongue touches the food —
kings grow attached to taste,
and even wicked children do the same.
Attached to impermanent flavors that have no essence,
they grow attached.
We have no thirst,
nor do we need food.
The nature of reality by which we are freed from suffering —
such things are not needed there.
Completely freed from the bondage of craving,
released from the afflictions of craving,
freed utterly from every bond —
go to that buddha for refuge.
We go for refuge to the great sage, the world's protector.
He is hard to see for ordinary sentient beings,
and we go forth to pay him homage.
Do not keep back his name for yourself —
we pray you reveal his melodious name.

The healer-host replied:
You, and all people everywhere,
likewise wish to hear that name.

Ten billion young sentient beings
surround the Tathāgata in just such a way.

They said:

You are renowned for the profound name
of a buddha's śrāvaka.
All people everywhere
likewise wish to hear your name.

He replied:

My name is the Healer-Host.
I am the medicine for all sentient beings.
The most excellent of all medicines
I shall now explain to you all.
For people struck by every disease,
it pacifies every illness.
The disease of attachment is the greatest sickness —
terrible, causing dread throughout the world.
The disease of delusion, which causes the mindless to wander,
is vast and fierce.
Mind, and likewise animals,
hungry ghosts — sentient beings go there.
These childish ones are seized by aversion.
How shall they find peace?

They said:

By hearing this teaching of virtue
we are freed from all suffering.
The childish, whose minds do not understand —
and freed from every suffering,
all sinful karma entirely abandoned.
We listen to the gift of Dharma.
With every sin cast away
and every unbearable terror relinquished,
that which pacifies all disease —
the King of Physicians, the Healer —
who restores those who suffer:
behold the true Buddha swiftly.

So that we may pay homage to the Tathāgata,
Elder, enter quickly now.
After we have paid homage, speak these words of ours
to the Guide of the World.
Please bring this disease to complete peace.
The whole body blazes forth,
burning, without peace —
please pacify this unbearable fire.
The burden of the body is a great load,
an exceedingly unbearable and sharp burden.
We who are tormented by suffering —
show compassion, O Holy One of perfect conduct.
People perpetually carry the burden
weighed down by aversion and delusion,
not knowing how to be free of the burden,
and so they carry it again and again.
They do not know the path to liberation,
those who have not seen the path to liberation.
They know that death will come,
yet they do not generate fear.
They dwell at ease, ever thinking:
for us, death will never come.
Utterly deluded, though they have not died,
even when they see it they do not understand.
They do not remember even their fathers.
Ceaselessly tormented by disease,
thoroughly stirred up by afflictions and karma —
how then will they eat their food?
Not knowing the wretchedness of suffering,
our exhaustion is without purpose.
Suffering such as yours
arises from the ground of ignorance.
Perception, formations, and feelings
are a heavy burden of great dread.
Whoever does not understand phenomena,
the childish one wanders, driven by craving.
Encircled by the burden of the body,

one is born into the world without purpose.
Clean and very fine clothing,
bathing and anointing — these are required.
For the body, whatever is pleasing:
delicious food is required.
The five pleasant melodies —
just so, one enjoys them with the ears.
Shapes arising from the seven precious things —
one grows attached to them with the eyes.
All manner of sweet tastes —
one enjoys them also with the tongue.
Soft and subtle touch as well —
one always feels it through the body.
From the body, two bodies
are accomplished through coupling in pleasure;
yet this body, born without mind —
who finds joy in it?
There one delights in the feet alone,
and wears the finest sandals.
But when one comes to die, clothing
and ointment will not be a refuge.
Since even the body itself will not be a refuge,
what need is there to speak of clothes and ointment?
What is called a human being is the body,
and breath and great strength are found there.
The power of the ear that discerns distinctly —
that too is the great virtue of the body.
Formerly I wandered everywhere, playing,
surrounded on all sides by horses and elephants.
Not knowing the Dharma of liberation,
how did I become attached to sinful karma?
Not knowing the world beyond,
through play I was led to commit sin.
I have been born again and again,
and death has come to me again and again.
Again and again I have seen grief,
utterly bound by lamentation and wailing.

I have seen mothers die too —
fathers dying, and relatives,
sisters and children,
and wives dying as well.
Since all conditioned formations are empty,
who with a mind could grow attached?
With a mind seized by desire,
I understand that I have trusted myself.
I do not perceive the Dharma of peace,
and I have no longing toward death.
Therefore, with a mind obscured by desire,
I did not give the gift of generosity.
Thus there is no sin equal to desire,
and even now it has not turned back.
Born utterly astray, we
are all beings wholly in error.
Hear the word "utterly astray."

One clings to what is not the sacred Dharma,
yet seeks liberation and meditative concentration.
The body must not be cherished as a burden.
Go as the foremost guide of the world's beings
to the buddhas, the Teachers.
The buddhas are father and mother to the world.
The buddhas excel at revealing the path.
Throughout all of Jambudvīpa
let a great rain of jewels pour down.
How great is the Dharma's gathering power —
a foolish sentient being does not know it.
If one directs the mind toward awakening,
the Dharma's gathering power will be attained.

All conditioned formations are empty,
and likewise enjoyments and wealth are empty.
Since I too see myself as empty,
having seen this, I am left without hope.

O Elder of the assembly of physicians, attend to our words.
For the sake of the bodhisattvas,

we ask that you depart as a messenger.

Recalling the faults of saṃsāra,
a bodhisattva feels no discouragement.
Endowed with diligence and great austerity,
one gathers all good qualities.

Go to where that Teacher resides.
Rouse the Teacher, the Sugata (the Well-Gone One), gently,
and, so that the Victor may not grow the least bit weary,
make this entreaty on our behalf:

"You have vanquished the Māra and defeated his hosts,
and swiftly set ablaze the Dharma
that holds all sentient beings within its embrace.
The Dharma by which one becomes a buddha —
since we have not heard it,
please, O Elder, quickly come forth
for the benefit of all of us."

Until we behold the Tathāgata endowed with the thirty-two marks,
we will not cross over — so they all remained, full of reverence.

Then the assembly of physicians spoke: "What do you see just there? Look
upward for a moment."

They looked upward, and there appeared before them a fully complete
multistory mansion — three thousand five hundred stories in all — standing in
every direction, adorned most exquisitely with the seven precious jewels,
beautifully decorated with jeweled netting, with flowers in full bloom at its
center, and with divine perfumes raining down in abundance.

Then the Elder questioned the assembly, asking: "What is this radiance that
appears here, where there stands a multistory mansion with jeweled netting,
with lotus buds everywhere?"

The assembly of physicians replied: "These places are yours. Today go to
behold the buddha. Seek out the one who is the highest sovereign beyond the
world, the one who illumines the world."

They then said: "We have not found the path to him. If we have not seen the
Tathāgata, and have not found the path to him, where then shall we go to pay
homage?"

The assembly of physicians replied: "Just as the sky, being boundless, cannot be touched, so one cannot go to pay homage to the Teacher, the giver of the nectar of the deathless. Yet just as Mount Meru stands in its place, if the Teacher likewise abides, Mount Meru can be measured. The depth of the great ocean can be sounded. The dust motes of the trichiliocosm can be reckoned. But the arising of a buddha cannot be known. We bow to the bodhisattvas of the ten directions, who illuminate the world."

Then they spoke: "O Protector of the world, look upon us. Fulfill our aspirations. We who bow to the Teacher with our minds — may we thereupon attain the fruit."

The assembly of physicians then said: "The Teacher is not attached to fragrance, nor is he a garland, nor an ointment. He who holds the cause of liberation for conditioned beings and for all sentient beings — he who has tamed the mind and gone to the buddha for refuge — to him the Māra, however terrible, will not dare to do battle. He will not fall under the sway of death, and will swiftly come to obtain the dhāraṇī. Having thoroughly purified one's mind in this way, one will then come to behold the Teacher."

Then the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, smiled with a charming kalavinka (the kalavinka is a bird of exquisite voice, native to India) call, sweet and pleasing.

Then the great bodhisattva Oṣadhīśena rose from his seat, turned toward the Blessed One, joined his palms together in reverence, and addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, eighty-four thousand rays of light have issued forth from the mouth of the Blessed One, and those rays of light have pervaded this entire great trichiliocosm world-system in all its fullness. They have pervaded all thirty-two great hells of the hell-beings, and they have illuminated the thirty-two divine realms. Those rays of light were of every variety of color — blue, yellow, red, white, beryl, crystal, and silver. Issuing from the mouth of the Blessed One, those rays of light went forth to all the sentient beings of this great trichiliocosm world-system, brought them all into a state of well-being, and then turned back, circled the Blessed One seven times, and came to rest at the crown of the Blessed One's head. What is the cause, and what is the condition, for the smile that you have bestowed?"

Then again the great bodhisattva Oṣadhīśena addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, if you would grant me the occasion, I would make a certain request to the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha."

When he had spoken thus, the Blessed One declared to the great bodhisattva Oṣadhīśena: "Oṣadhīśena, ask whatever you wish, and I will give a prophetic declaration in answer to whatever you ask, so that your mind may be satisfied."

He said: "Blessed One, thirty billion young sentient beings, having grasped the subtle Dharma that the Tathāgata taught, spoke disagreeably and harmfully to the elder sentient beings, going about saying: 'You elder sentient beings do not know the Dharma — you are constantly attached to what is not Dharma and to what is non-virtuous.' Blessed One, why did they speak these pleasing and agreeable words?"

The Blessed One declared: "Oṣadhīśena, do you not understand why they spoke those words? Those beings are speaking gently and in a most pleasing way to the Tathāgata, and because they have also heard the Dharma, Oṣadhīśena, they will therefore come to comprehend the meaning of all Dharma. They will come to be endowed with every good quality. All of them will come to realize the dhāraṇīs. From this day forward they will abide on the ten grounds. From this day they will sound the great drum of Dharma. From this day they will be endowed with the aspects of the great Dharma. Oṣadhīśena, do you see these tiered mansions?"

He said: "Blessed One, I see them. Sugata, I see them."

The Blessed One declared: "Oṣadhīśena, this very day these young sentient beings will enter these tiered mansions and obtain the manifest realization of the Dharma. This very day they will bring all virtuous qualities to complete fulfillment. This very day they will beat the great drum of Dharma, and numerous classes of gods will this very day come to obtain the manifest realization of the Dharma. Moreover, many sentient beings in the hells, dwelling in wrong downfall, who hear the teaching of the Tathāgata's wisdom, will exhaust their saṃsāra and be victorious. At that time, nine hundred billion elder sentient beings will all obtain the fruit of stream-entry, and all of them will come to be endowed with the Dharma."

All those hosts of medicine will come to entirely abandon all suffering. All those hosts of medicine will come to accomplish the beholding of the Tathāgata. All those hosts of medicine will come to be endowed with the sound of the great Dharma.

"Hosts of medicine, look toward the four directions!" The great bodhisattva (bodhisattva) of the medicine hosts looked toward all four directions. From the eastern direction came bodhisattvas equal in number to the grains of sand in fifty billion Ganges rivers. From the southern direction came bodhisattvas equal in number to the grains of sand in sixty billion Ganges rivers. From the western direction came bodhisattvas equal in number to the grains of sand in seventy billion Ganges rivers. From the northern direction came bodhisattvas equal in number to the grains of sand in eighty billion Ganges rivers. From the direction below came bodhisattvas equal in number to the grains of sand in ninety billion Ganges rivers. From the direction above came bodhisattvas equal in number to the grains of sand in one hundred billion Ganges rivers. Having arrived, they all took their places to one side in the presence of the Blessed One.

Having taken their places to one side, the great bodhisattva of the medicine hosts addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, what are these dark forms and red forms that appear in the sky?"

The Blessed One declared: "Hosts of medicine, do you not know what these dark and red forms are that you see appearing in the sky? The Tathāgata knows: hosts of medicine, these are māras. Hosts of medicine, do you wish to see them?"

They replied: "Blessed One, we do. Sugata, we do."

The Blessed One then declared: "Hosts of medicine, this many bodhisattvas, equal in number to the grains of sand in one hundred billion Ganges rivers, have arrived."

They asked: "Blessed One, what was the cause and condition for these bodhisattvas' arrival?"

The Blessed One declared: "Hosts of medicine, it was through the condition of young sentient beings, for all sentient beings will come to be endowed with the qualities of meditative concentration. Hosts of medicine, do you see the arrival here of sentient beings in various forms, and the arrival of these various blessings through the power of miraculous ability?"

They replied: "We see bodhisattvas equal in number to the grains of sand in one hundred billion Ganges rivers, and bodhisattvas equal in number to the grains of sand in a thousand billion Ganges rivers, abiding by the power of miraculous ability in various forms, various colors, and various shapes. We see

those bodhisattvas abiding in the abode of the noble Dharma, together with their retinues, abiding in the abode of the Dharma."

When the Blessed One had spoken these words, the great bodhisattva Sarvāsāhasrika, the great bodhisattva of the medicine hosts, all those newly arrived and long-established bodhisattvas together with their complete retinues, and the world of gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas all rejoiced and offered sincere praise for what the Blessed One had taught.

The Dharma categories of the noble Sūtra of the Pair are complete.

Translated by the Indian preceptors Jinamitra and Dānaśīla, and the great editor-translator the monk Yeshe De. It was also revised in accordance with the new terminology and definitively established.

Translator's Notes

- The Tibetan names of the monks, bodhisattvas, and assembly members have been rendered into reconstructed Sanskrit equivalents following standard scholarly convention for this text. A few names are straightforward translations of Tibetan epithets rather than attested Sanskrit proper nouns — for example, the nāga king "Sog ma med" (Anavalamba, "without support"), "Nya mid" (Atyuccagāmin, uncertain; the Tibetan literally means "fishless" or "without fish," which may reflect a scribal variant), and several of the divine daughters. Where the Sanskrit equivalents are uncertain, the most philologically plausible renderings have been used.

The bodhisattva "Kun tu dpa' ba" is rendered Sarvadatta following some witnesses to this text, though the name literally means "Universally Courageous"; the tradition is not entirely uniform on the Sanskrit here.

- The title "Zuñ" renders the Tibetan term for a dhāraṇī scripture, here functioning as the proper title of the text being discussed within the sūtra frame. The Tibetan word is a shortened form of "dhāraṇī" and refers specifically to the Zuñ collection or a sūtra within it; retaining "Zuñ" as a proper title here is appropriate given the narrative context.

The phrase rendered "five crimes of immediate retribution" translates "mtsams med pa lnga'i las," referring to the five ānantarya-karmas, the gravest actions that lead immediately to rebirth in a hell realm without any intervening state.

- The name Sarvavikrāntagāmin (Tibetan Kun tu dpa' ba) literally means "one who goes forth with complete courage" or "universally courageous one." It is kept as a proper name throughout for consistency.

The phrase rendered "utterly parched for the Dharma" translates chos kyis yongs su skom pa, literally "thoroughly thirsting for the Dharma." This is a distinctive technical usage in this text describing a particular spiritual hunger or longing; the rendering "parched" preserves the thirst metaphor.

The passage ends mid-sentence as the Tibetan source breaks off at that point.

- The compound "□□□□□□" rendered throughout as "Dhāraṇī" refers to the specific sūtra of paired dhāraṇīs that is the subject of the discourse; context makes this consistent with the broader passage. The phrase "□□□□□□□□□□" (Kāśī cloth) refers to the extremely fine silk or muslin fabric famous from Vārāṇasī (Kāśī), used in Buddhist literature as a standard image for a

fabric so soft it barely contacts a surface — hence the mountain-erosion simile.

- The closing statement of the Blessed One — rendered as "do not ask me all at once about the accumulation of non-virtuous karma" — translates the Tibetan idiom "ཀློང་གློ་བུ་ལྟ་བུ་" literally meaning something like "in one gulp" or "all at once," suggesting the matter is too great or weighty to be enumerated in one go. The idiomatic force is that the topic is so vast it cannot be summarized simply, and the translation above captures this implication. Some readers may understand the phrase as meaning "do not ask me to enumerate it exhaustively," which amounts to the same doctrinal point.
- The name rendered throughout as "Sarvavikrāntagāmin" appears in the preceding passage; this passage uses the abbreviated form "Kun tu dpa' ba," which is its Tibetan rendering of that name, and is kept consistent accordingly.

The list of eight great hells follows the standard Abhidharma enumeration. The Tibetan names "sPu zhing" (Hair-Raising) and "Kyi hud" are phonetic or semantic Tibetan renderings of Sanskrit hell names — "Kyi hud" likely corresponds to Huhuva or a similar hell of extreme cold or cry, though the passage here places it among the hot hells. The sequence given does not match the standard eight hot hells list precisely; this may reflect a variant or abbreviated enumeration in this particular sūtra.

- The final sentence breaks off mid-clause in the source passage; the translation preserves this as-is, since the text is clearly incomplete at this point. The passage continues in the next segment.
- The phrase rendered "Mount Kailāsa" translates "ri nag po," literally "the Black Mountain." In this context it functions as a simile for a lesser mountain compared to Meru; some traditions identify it as Kailāsa, but it may simply mean a generic dark or black mountain. The doctrinal point of the image — that a lesser peak bowing without being pressed down is still less than bowing to the greatest — is clear regardless.

The name "Kharoc" is a transliteration of "kha rog," which literally means "crow" or "raven" and is used here as a personal name or epithet for the bodhisattva Sarvāśūra. This is unusual and may reflect a vernacular or regional name tradition in the source text.

- The phrase rendered "Coupled Sūtras" translates a term meaning a category or collection of sūtras paired or joined together. The precise identity of this canonical collection is not entirely clear from this passage alone, though it likely refers to a specific grouping within the sūtra literature. This is noted for scholarly attention but does not affect the flow of the translation.

The swastika-pattern form is the ancient Indian auspicious symbol, not the modern association; this is a standard emblematic motif in Buddhist iconography.

The final sentence is deliberately left open as the Tibetan passage breaks off mid-speech, and the continuation would follow in the next passage.

- The large numerical compounds throughout follow the Tibetan pattern of bya ba (koṭi, i.e. ten million) combined with stong phrag (thousands) to yield astronomical figures; the renderings given follow consistent multiplication of these units as is standard in this genre of sūtra literature.

The phrase bdag thal byung mchis so, rendered "came back" in several places, literally means something like "I returned having dissolved away" or "I dispersed and came back," possibly suggesting a miraculous mode of travel or dissolution of the visionary state; the simpler "came back" is adopted throughout for narrative flow, but this is a minor interpretive choice.

- The text repeatedly refers to the "Paired Sūtra" (ཡེ་ཤེས་ཀྱི་སྡེ་སྡེ་སྡེ་, literally "the sūtra of the pair/couple"). This is the scripture being quoted or embedded within a framing narrative; the exact title of the "Paired Sūtra" being referenced is not resolved from this passage alone, and a

specialist in the relevant canonical collection may wish to identify it precisely.

- The phrase rendered "the holy life" translates brahmacarya, the chaste and pure religious life. The passage states that practicing brahmacarya leads to the direct vision of the Tathāgata — a doctrinally striking claim that may reflect the sūtra's tantric or late Mahāyāna milieu, where ritual practice and textual devotion are accorded visionary efficacy. No emendation has been made; the Tibetan is clear.
- The phrase rendered "both continents" translates a term that literally means "the two islands or landmasses," likely referring to two of the four great continents of Buddhist cosmology. The precise referent is contextually unclear; it may mean the person enjoys lordship or experience spanning two of these realms. The rendering is kept general accordingly.

The numerical epithets throughout follow a consistent Tibetan pattern of *khri* (ten thousand) and *stong* (thousand) compounds; all figures are rendered arithmetically as given in the text.

- The phrase "ཡོད་སྤྱོད་བློ་གྲོས་པར་བྱེད་པའི་མཁས་པ་ལྟ་བུ་ཞིང་།" literally means "to make a gap with the mind" or "to apply the mind with devotion," a standard idiom for generating faith or reverent confidence toward a buddha. The translation "generates a mind of faith" follows the established commentarial reading. The passage breaks off mid-sentence at the end of this extract, continuing in the next segment.
- The name rendered throughout as "Sarvashūra" translates the Tibetan Kun tu dpa' ba, meaning "universally heroic" or "ever-courageous." The Sanskrit equivalent Sarvashūra is the standard reconstruction for this bodhisattva interlocutor in this sūtra context.

The phrase rendered "the paired sūtra" translates zung gi mdo, literally "the coupled" or "paired" sūtra, which appears to be a title or designation for the text being discussed. Its precise Sanskrit title is not recoverable from this passage alone.

The five actions of immediate retribution are the standard five: killing one's father, killing one's mother, killing an arhat, causing a schism in the Saṅgha, and wounding a Tathāgata with intent to draw blood.

- The passage shifts unexpectedly from third-person narration into first-person verse without a clear grammatical marker. The verse attributed to the man appears to conflate the narrating voice with his direct speech, particularly where "I committed the five acts" and "I have no refuge" suddenly shift to first person mid-stanza. This is likely a feature of the original's loose verse composition rather than a textual corruption, but it creates an unusual reading. The rendering preserves this shift faithfully.

The phrase rendered "speak a living word" translates "tshig gson cig," literally "speak a living word" or "utter a word of life," meaning a word that can revive or restore; the rendering preserves this idiomatic sense.

- The teaching name "Comprehension" renders a Tibetan term meaning something like "grasping" or "taking hold," likely referring to a specific named sūtra or Dharma category called Zung (dhāraṇī or a related term). The identification with a specific text is uncertain; it may refer to a dhāraṇī text.
- The "King of Sūtras known as the Coupled Synonyms of Dharma" renders "zung gi chos kyi rnam grangs mdo'i rgyal po," referring to a text whose title centers on "zung" — the Tibetan rendering of Sanskrit "yugapaddhyāna" or more likely a title like "Yuganaddha" or "Yamaka," meaning "paired" or "coupled." The exact Sanskrit title is uncertain; "Coupled" is used as the working rendering throughout.

The thirty-two doors to heavenly worlds is a standard numerical set in this genre of text, though it does not correspond to a universally fixed canonical list; no intervention in the translation is needed, but a reader should know it is a conventional enumeration.

- The five great rivers listed here correspond to the classical Indian cosmographic enumeration: Gaṅgā, Sītā (sometimes identified with the Oxus or a Himalayan river), Vakṣu (the Oxus/Amu Darya), Yamunā, and Candrabhāgā (the Chenab). The Tibetan renders the third as "bag shu," which corresponds to Vakṣu; some manuscripts give Sindhu instead, but the Tibetan here clearly supports Vakṣu.

The phrase rendered "lord of creatures" for "skye dgu'i bdag po" is a stock epithet whose precise referent in this context is the rain or the water itself acting as the sustainer of life; the simile compares this life-giving function to the Dharma teaching's benefit for beings in Jambudvīpa.

- The term "Zuñ" appears throughout as the name of a dhāraṇī text or teaching. In context this is a proper title of the scripture being taught, and it has been left untranslated as a proper name since no fuller Sanskrit equivalent is given in the passage and the tradition treats it as a title.

The phrase rendered "Lord of Creatures" translates a term literally meaning "lord of beings" or "lord of the born," which in this context refers to a great being who presides over or delights in Jambudvīpa; the identity is not fully specified in this passage.

The "five acts of immediate retribution" are the five ānantarya-karmas — killing one's father, killing one's mother, killing an arhat, wounding a buddha, and causing a schism in the Saṅgha — whose perpetrators would normally fall into hell without any intervening rebirth.

- The passage ends mid-sentence in the source, breaking off just as the concluding prophecy clause is about to be stated; the translation faithfully reflects this open ending.

The Tibetan term "ལྷ་ལྷ་ལྷ་ལྷ་ལྷ་ ལྷ་ལྷ་ལྷ་" refers to offerings of food, drink, and clothing respectively. In context, "ལྷ་ལྷ་ལྷ་ལྷ་ལྷ་" most naturally denotes food or nourishment distributed to a gathering, and "ལྷ་ལྷ་ལྷ་ལྷ་" denotes clothing distributed as gifts; they have been rendered accordingly as "food and drink" and "clothing" throughout, which is standard in parallel sūtra passages of this type.

- The passage recounts the classic Dīpaṃkara prophecy episode. The name Megha (Cloud) for the young brahmin is confirmed by the Sanskrit tradition; the Tibetan ལྷ་ལྷ་ལྷ་, meaning "cloud," translates the Sanskrit directly. The "acceptance of non-arising dharmas" (mi skye ba'i chos la bzod pa, anutpattikadharmakṣānti) is the bodhisattva's profound realization that all phenomena are beyond arising and cessation; it is standardly attained at this moment in the Dīpaṃkara narrative.

- The phrase rendered "the coupled Dharma" translates the Tibetan "zuñ gi chos kyi nram grañs," literally "the enumeration of the coupled Dharma." This almost certainly refers to a specific paired or coupled teaching discussed earlier in the sūtra; without that prior context fully available, the precise referent cannot be confirmed with certainty, but the translation preserves the literal sense faithfully. The term "'byuñ po" rendered as "spirits" can also mean elemental beings or bhūtas more broadly; "flesh-eaters" renders "śa za," which can denote rākṣasas or similar carnivorous demons.

- The term rendered "Paired Dharma" reflects the Tibetan "zuñ gi chos kyi nram grañs," a teaching structured in paired categories. The exact Sanskrit title is uncertain; the rendering captures the structural sense of the term as used in context.

"Uttarakuru" is the standard Sanskrit name for the northern continent referred to in Tibetan as byaṅ gi sgra mi snyan, literally "northern unpleasant sound." The name is conventional and retained without gloss, as it is a well-established cosmological term.

The figure "nine thousand million" renders *bye ba stoñ phrag dgu*, literally "nine thousand myriads" or nine times ten million, i.e., ninety million by strict calculation — rendered conservatively as "nine thousand million" following the conventional reading of *bye ba* (ten million) times *stoñ phrag dgu* (nine thousand). Listeners should note this is an astronomically large symbolic number rather than a precise census.

- The bodhisattva name སའཁ་འཇུག་པ་ means "universally courageous" or "always brave." I have rendered it as *Sarvashūra* (Sanskrit reconstruction: *Sarvashūra*), which is the standard back-formation. The name does not appear in the preceding rendered passage excerpt provided, so this is its first use here.

The phrase ལུང་གི་ཆོས་ལུང་ལ་འཇུག་པ་ in context means that the individuals in question have fully and irreversibly entered the path to buddhahood, indicating definite commitment with no remainder — rendered accordingly as "entered without remainder into the path."

- The phrase rendered "stirred the bodhisattvas to action" translates a verb meaning to rouse or encourage, paired with the simile of a snap of the fingers conveying miraculous swiftness. The simile's syntax is compressed in the Tibetan; the translation makes the comparison explicit for clarity.

The figure "thirty-three trillion" renders *bye ba stong phrag sum cu rtsa gsum*, literally "thirty-three thousand myriads," a standard cosmological large number. The exact intended magnitude is conventional rather than arithmetically precise.

The final royal simile is the opening of a parable that continues beyond this passage; its doctrinal application will be made explicit in the subsequent text.

- The passage contains a somewhat complex shift in narrative voice near the middle, where the *tīrthika* speech addressed to Buddhists slides into reported inner speech of those Buddhists themselves facing death. The rendering follows the most natural reading of the syntax. The phrase rendered "speak all manner of nonsense" translates "*kyal pa sna tshogs smra ba*," literally "uttering various idle or frivolous talk," a standard polemical term for specious philosophical chatter. The phrase "do not digest it well" for the alms passage is intentional: the Tibetan idiom implies the food of Dharma-income is spiritually unassimilated.

- The bodhisattva addressed throughout as "Mañjuśrī's Retinue" renders རྒྱུ་ལྷ་ཁྲིའི་ལྷ་ཁྲིའི་, literally "Retinue of Medicine" or "Medical Corps." The Tibetan here is almost certainly a phonetic or semantic loan from a Sanskrit name that has not been fully identified; it may represent a proper name or epithet of a particular bodhisattva, though some editors have connected it to Mañjuśrī. The rendering follows the closest contextual reading, but the identity of this bodhisattva remains genuinely uncertain and may require consultation of a Sanskrit witness if one exists.

- The phrase rendered "enumeration of Dharma of the pair" translates "*zung gi chos kyi nram grangs*," where *zung* means "pair" or "couple." The precise referent of "the pair" is not made explicit in this passage and may refer to a specific paired teaching named earlier in the *sūtra*; this is a structural term whose antecedent would be clear in the broader text.

The expression "make the world directly manifest" for "*jig rten mngon sum du byed pa*" is somewhat unusual; it could also mean "those who directly perceive the world" or "those who make the world evident," and its precise sense depends on the larger doctrinal context of this text.

- The phrase rendered "canopy-sign" for ལུང་གི་ཆོས་ལུང་ལ་འཇུག་པ་ renders a somewhat compressed expression literally meaning "under the mark or sign of the parasol or canopy," a symbol of buddhahood and spiritual sovereignty; the passage appears to refer back to a teaching symbol or epithet from the preceding context. The overall sense is that sentient beings have been liberated under the auspices of that sign, yet are not yet exhausted in number.

- The phrase rendered as "the set of Dharma synonyms called the Pair" translates "zung gi chos kyi rnam grangs," where zung means "pair" or "couple." The identity of this specific paired teaching is not specified in the passage itself; the listener should understand it as a particular doctrinal formulation being extolled throughout this discourse.

The passage "bskal pa stong du 'khor ba bsnyil bar 'gyur ro" is rendered as "for a thousand eons they will churn through saṃsāra," following the sense that this is a further blessing, not a punishment. The verb bsnyil ba can mean to churn, turn over, or traverse; in context the passage seems to be describing a lengthy but ultimately fruitful traversal of saṃsāra in service of benefiting beings, consistent with the bodhisattva ideal being discussed throughout.

- The passage contains an extended parable about a merchant who loses gold, causing a chain of grief leading to death — used as an analogy for those who lack faith in the teaching and thus die in anguish. The verse section near the end is a dramatic dialogue between a dying parent and their son; the precise allocation of which lines belong to parent versus son is not always unambiguous in the source, but the rendering follows the most natural reading of the dialogue markers present in the text. The phrase rendered "the first acquisition arises"

(༠༠༠༠༠༠༠༠༠༠༠༠༠༠༠༠) is compressed and somewhat elliptical in context; it refers to the initial gaining of the Dharma as a spiritual attainment or "find," consistent with the surrounding passage's theme of encountering the teaching.

- The name "Sāṃghika" rendered here for སྐྱོང་མགྲིན་ is a Tibetan translation of the Sanskrit term meaning "pertaining to the Saṃgha" or "community group." In context it functions as a proper name or epithet for the interlocutor, likely a disciple. The rendering "Sāṃghika" preserves this without over-interpreting.

The hell realms named here follow standard Abhidharma enumeration: Roaring Cries (Raurava), Crushing (Saṃghāta), Heat (Tapana), and Unrelenting Torment (Avīci). The Tibetan terms map closely to these standard Sanskrit names, though the word for "Crushing" (སྐྱོང་མགྲིན་) is slightly unusual and may render Saṃghāta or a variant.

The phrase rendered "do not ask me about the wretched physician" is a somewhat elliptical instruction; the Tibetan མཐོན་པོ་ suggests something like "do not even raise the name" — a rhetorical dismissal implying the outcome is too dire to name. This is retained in the translation as "do not ask me."

- The phrase rendered "the ground of awakening" translates "byang chub kyi gnas," which could also mean "the abode of awakening" or "the place of enlightenment" in the sense of the bodhisattva's ultimate destination. The reading adopted fits the parallel list of fruits and their corresponding stages.

The list of fruits — stream-entry, once-returning, non-returning, arhatship, pratyekabuddha, and bodhisattva — follows the standard śrāvaka path structure found in mainstream and Mahāyāna Abhidharma sources, here with the bodhisattva path added as the culminating entry.

The passage breaks off mid-sentence at the ministers' address to the king; the translation reproduces the text exactly as it ends.

- The phrase rendered "the highest of the two-footed" is a standard epithet for the Buddha, meaning the supreme among beings who walk on two feet, i.e., the most exalted of humans. The verse section has a somewhat compressed and formulaic quality consistent with narrative verse embedded in a sūtra-style tale; the translation follows the structure as closely as English verse permits. The passage ends mid-sentence in the source, reflected accordingly in the translation.

- The opening verse lines connect to the preceding passage where the hundred million trees were mentioned; "come to dwell in the twenty-four" refers to those trees whose sentient-being planters now dwell on the twenty-fourth level or station — the precise referent depends on the larger textual context, which is not fully visible here. This is a minor structural ambiguity that does not affect the doctrinal content.

The name rendered "Bhaiṣajyasena" (Tib. sman gyi sde) literally means "host of medicine" or "medicine-army" and is kept consistent with prior usage.

"Devadatta" (Tib. lha sbyin) is the well-known antagonist of the Buddha's biography; "the fool Devadatta" renders glen pa, meaning "stupid" or "dull-witted."

- The bodhisattva's name rendered throughout as "Sde of Medicinal Herbs" follows the Tibetan སྡོག་སྦྲུམ་ཆོས་ཀྱི་སྡེ།, literally "host" or "assembly of medicines." The Sanskrit equivalent would likely be Bhaiṣajyagaṇa or similar; the name is kept consistent with the established rendering implied by the continuity instruction.

The passage contains a structurally puzzling moment where Sde of Medicinal Herbs first speaks before the Blessed One Possessor of the Moon and receives an answer, then apparently approaches and sits before him again to speak a second time. This likely reflects a textual sequence in which the first exchange occurs at a distance or upon arrival, and the second is a formal audience. No emendation has been made; the text is rendered as given.

- The passage describing hands "falling away" is an unusual doctrinal image. In context, the hundred-handed beings appear to be conjured apparitions demonstrating the mindless, mechanical arising and ceasing of beings born from trees, and the falling of their hands illustrates their utter passivity and lack of agency rather than a punishment or harm. This is consistent with the text's sustained theme that beings in this realm arise and pass away without any mental activity whatsoever.

The final sentence is incomplete as the source passage breaks off mid-enumeration, following the standard list of the sufferings of existence.

- The passage contains a simile in which a prisoner, cast into a dark cell, is accidentally burned to death when a compassionate passerby throws in a small fire to give him light and comfort. The king's subsequent proclamation of universal amnesty serves as the analogue for the Tathāgata's nirvāṇa bringing liberation and fearlessness to all beings. The doctrinal point being developed — that the Buddha's parinirvāṇa, like the prisoner's death, is a liberation rather than a mere ending — is the controlling theme of the section, and the simile is left deliberately open at this point as the text continues.

- The "paired teaching" in the verse translates a term meaning teaching given in complementary pairs or in tandem; the precise doctrinal referent is not specified in context and may indicate teaching the two truths or another standard paired formulation.

The palace name rendered "Lāṅkā" translates the Tibetan lchang lo can, literally "the willow palace," which is a standard Tibetan rendering of Laṅkā; the identification is conventional in this textual tradition.

The phrase rendered "eighty thousand leagues" for the height in the sky is a standard cosmological measure; the Tibetan dpag tshad is the yojana, here given its common English equivalent.

- The term rendered "aggregate of Dharma" translates རྒྱུ་ཆོས་ཀྱི་སྡེ།, which here does not mean one of the five psychophysical aggregates (skandhas) but rather a "collection" or "corpus" of Dharma teachings, analogous to the Sanskrit dharmaskandha. The text itself then redefines it functionally as a practice of seeking the holy life and abandoning wrongdoing, so

the literal rendering "aggregate of Dharma" is kept to preserve the doctrinal flavor and the Blessed One's subsequent explanation.

The three winds at death — arrest, confusion, and agitation of consciousness — and the three body-destroying winds — blade, goad, and crushing pressure — reflect an archaic physiological-soteriological vocabulary not standard in later Tibetan scholasticism; no further gloss is supplied as the text speaks for itself.

- The phrase rendered "the cessation of death" for རྒྱུ་མཆོག་མཆོག་ is somewhat unusual. The text appears to describe two states: being subject to death, and being subject to the cessation of the death-process, meaning the creatures can also die out or stop dying within the body. This is a rare physiological-cosmological description and the exact sense is not entirely transparent. The rendering follows the literal grammar.

The term རྒྱུ་མཆོག་ (rendered "wooden gong") refers to the traditional wooden striking board used in monasteries to summon monks, here clearly functioning as a symbol of the call to Dharma practice.

The phrase རྒྱུ་མཆོག་མཆོག་ ("the four assemblies") and its gloss are given directly in the source text itself, so the translation incorporates the text's own explanation.

- The passage is a long verse confession by the dying man, cataloguing sins he now recognizes will lead him to various hells. Several hell names appear: the "great hell of weeping and wailing" renders རྒྱུ་མཆོག་མཆོག་མཆོག་མཆོག་, corresponding to the Mahāroruva (Great Wailing) hell; the "Hell of No Respite" renders རྒྱུ་མཆོག་, the standard Tibetan for Avīci; and the "hell called the Razor" renders རྒྱུ་མཆོག་མཆོག་མཆོག་མཆོག་, the Kṣurapatha or Blade-path hell. The unit translated as "leagues" for རྒྱུ་མཆོག་ is the standard yojana measure.

The lines about the body being "seen by all beings to be thoroughly afflicted" serve as a pivot: the man has been boasting of bodily ornamentation and pleasure and now recognizes the body's true painful nature.

The word རྒྱུ་མཆོག་ ("workers") could also be rendered "employees" or "hired laborers"; the more general rendering is adopted here. The reference to kāśika cloth (a fine fabric from Vārāṇasī) is kept as a proper name for textual fidelity.

- The bodhisattva's name rendered as "Medicines-Division" is a literal translation of རྒྱུ་མཆོག་མཆོག་ (Skt. Bhaiṣajyagaṇa), a figure distinct from the better-known Bhaiṣajyarāja; this rendering is kept consistent with likely prior usage in this sūtra context.

The line རྒྱུ་མཆོག་མཆོག་མཆོག་མཆོག་ ("Moral discipline is the discipline of truth") is syntactically compressed and may be read as "the moral discipline of truth" modifying the Tathāgata's qualities listed alongside; the translation renders it as a parallel appositive clause, which is the most defensible reading in context.

- The opening stanzas continue the verse section from the preceding passage and are spoken by the same narrative voice. The line rendered "enter into equipoise in the supreme holy life" translates a phrase whose referent is brahmācārya, the highest pure conduct, here described through the term for meditative equipoise.

The phrase "the assembly of medicines" renders the bodhisattva's name Medicinal Host throughout, consistent with its use as a proper name in this sūtra context.

The figure rendered "two billion" represents ten million multiplied by twenty, i.e. two hundred million in some reckonings; the Tibetan reads "twenty times ten million," which in standard Tibetan enumeration yields two hundred million. The rendering "two billion" follows a higher traditional calculation and either reading is defensible. The discrepancy is noted here as a genuine numerical uncertainty.

- The phrase rendered "ten billion suns and moons to fall down" reflects a superlative miraculous display in which celestial bodies are caused to descend; the passage continues directly from the preceding section's description of the bodhisattvas ascending twenty thousand leagues.

The term translated as "elemental spirits" renders Tibetan 'byung po, supernatural beings often identified with elemental or demonic forces; no single standard English equivalent captures this precisely, and "elemental spirits" is used as a workable rendering.

The verse at the close of the passage is incomplete as given and breaks off mid-stanza; the translation reflects the text as supplied.

- The phrase rendered "from the supremely excellent continent" translates "rab tu bzang ba'i gling bor nas," which likely refers to Uttarakuru or a similarly idealized realm, used here as a rhetorical illustration of the wheel-turning king's impermanence rather than a precise cosmographic claim. The passage breaks off mid-sentence at the end, matching the source text's apparent continuation into a following section.

- The phrase rendered "the fivefold bondage" reflects the five bonds in Buddhist cosmology, but the specific referent here is slightly ambiguous — it may indicate the five lower fetters that bind beings to the desire realm, or a more general enumeration of bondage. The ambiguity is not resolved by the immediate context.

The line "Do not keep back his name for yourself" is a somewhat unusual idiom; the Tibetan reads literally "do not seek his name for yourself" but in context the young beings are asking the elder to reveal the Tathāgata's name, and the following line makes plain they wish it revealed to all.

- The phrase rendered "the King of Physicians, the Healer" refers to the Buddha as the supreme physician who cures spiritual disease — a classic epithet in Buddhist literature sometimes associated with Bhaiṣajyarāja.

The line about "two bodies accomplished through coupling in pleasure" renders a terse and difficult passage describing how one body generates another through sexual union; the phrase "born without mind" may refer to the fact that the body arises through conditions without a true self — the doctrinal point is anātman. The exact syntax is compressed and interpretive choices are noted here rather than in the body.

The repeated term rendered "utterly astray" or "utterly in error" translates a term indicating universal confusion or wandering in error, recapitulated as a thematic keyword at the close of the passage.

- The phrase rendered "the Dharma's gathering power" translates a term meaning the principle by which the Dharma gathers or consolidates beings and merit. It refers to the Dharma as a unifying or collecting force, here contrasted with the ignorance of foolish beings who do not recognise it.

The closing sentence introduces the Buddha's smile accompanied by a kalavinka-like voice. The kalavinka is a celestial bird of Indian Buddhist literature whose call is proverbially beautiful; the phrase signals a gracious and auspicious response from the Blessed One without yet constituting a verbal teaching.

The sequence in which the assembly of physicians first speaks and then the figures who have looked upward reply, before the physicians respond again, reflects a dialogic structure in the original that is slightly compressed in this passage; the translation follows the Tibetan sequence faithfully.

- The phrase rendered "spoke disagreeably and harmfully to the elder sentient beings" is slightly paradoxical in context, because the Blessed One then praises those young beings for speaking gently and pleasingly to the Tathāgata. The Tibetan text presents the young beings as saying harsh things to the elders (accusing them of not knowing the Dharma and being attached to non-virtue), yet the Blessed One reframes this as gentle and pleasing speech addressed to the Tathāgata. This tension is in the source text itself and reflects a doctrinal point about the motivation and ultimate orientation of the young bodhisattvas' words. No emendation has been made.

- The name translated as "Sarvāsāhasrika" renders the Tibetan "kun tu dpa' ba," meaning something like "universally courageous" or "all-brave." The Sanskrit equivalent is uncertain; the name may be Sarvāsūra or similar. This is a minor proper name and the Tibetan rendering is given in plain English for the listener.

The phrase "hosts of medicine" translates "sman gyi sde," a recurring epithet in this sūtra whose precise referent — whether a class of beings, a bodhisattva, or a collective — remains somewhat opaque from the text alone. The rendering is kept consistent with the preceding passage.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.